Aperture

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by Malefícar

Summary

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>
> Castorice rolls her eyes. “As if plating isn’t just sculpture with food.”
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> He opens his mouth to fire back a snide rejoinder, realizes she’s right, and holds his tongue instead. She’s doing him a favor, forcing him out of his house, one of his only friends who’s stuck with him over the past year of tremendous, never-ending grief. No one knows how to deal with a widower’s pain and loss. No one wants to. But Castorice has faced even more death than he has, and she hasn’t let him pull away from the world despite his attempts.

After the unexpected death of his partner, Khaslana, about a year ago, Mydei meets photographer Phainon at a gallery exhibition he's forced to attend by his friend, Castorice. Unexpected sparks fly between them as they grow closer through Phainon's photography.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mydei's stomach churns. His palms sweat. He has half a mind to turn around and go home, but Castorice, crowds his exit and prevents his escape.

"I really do think you'll like his work," Castorice says as they pass through the foyer and into the gallery proper.

"As if I have any eye for art," Mydei replies. Art galleries have always left him feeling vaguely left out, as if everyone else grasps something about what's on display that's just beyond him.

Castorice rolls her eyes. "As if plating isn't just sculpture with food."

He opens his mouth to fire back a snide rejoinder, realizes she's right, and holds his tongue instead. She's doing him a favor, forcing him out of his house, one of his only friends who's stuck with him over the past year of tremendous, never-ending grief. No one knows how to deal with a widower's pain and loss. No one wants to. But Castorice has faced even more death than he has, and she hasn't let him pull away from the world despite his attempts.

"Phainon's exhibiting in the Pearl Gallery," she says, leading him through a series of surprisingly crowded rooms. People gather around sublime landscapes and intimate portraits, around modern sculptures that cross Mydei's eyes and hurt his brain, around canvas stapled directly to the walls and splattered with paint. "But we can look at the rest if you'd like," she adds, drawing up on the threshold between two gallery spaces.

She wants him to spend more time out of the house, but he wants to get back home as quickly as possible to—to what? Sit in an empty home, devoid of laughter? Khaslana's passing still cuts like a knife. His therapist says sudden and unexpected loss is like that. That he'll grow around his pain with time. He's not sure he believes her.

Forcing a little laugh, he steps into the Pearl Gallery. "Why don't we start here and see where the evening takes us?" he asks, which will placate her for now.

Her narrow-eyed gaze tells him she knows he's bullshitting her, but she's a good enough friend not to call him out. "That's fine, then." She veers to the right, where a photograph hangs on a white wall beneath a downturned lamp.

Yellow lamplight, warm and soft, illuminates the black and white photo drenched in heavy shadow. Despite Castorice's earlier reassurance, Mydei really doesn't know anything about art. He doesn't know how to pick apart the composition or understand the lightning, but maybe he doesn't need to. Just looking at the photograph rocks him. Two men, folded around each other, only the bottoms of their faces visible, their arms a tangle, their bodies intermingled in uncomfortably raw intimacy. Their missing faces should be dehumanizing,

but the nod to preserving the secret of their identities makes the photograph even more visceral, as if they've been caught in this moment rather than having posed for it.

"Oh," Castorice says softly. "Maybe this isn't the best piece to start with."

Maybe it isn't. Maybe it reminds him too much of Khaslana and the nights they spent wrapped in each other's arms. But rather than inspire a swelling of grief, the photo fills him with a quiet, cozy nostalgia.

"It's beautiful," Mydei says.

Castorice perks up, tugging him to the next piece. It, too, is entirely in black and white, its focus just as soft as the last. Light pours over a trans man's side turned body, highlighting his scars. Feather drip from his outstretched arms. A plaque beside the photo reads simply *Samothrace*.

"Phainon's whole thing is capturing queer bodies," Castorice says. "I can't remember his artist statement for this show, but it's something about the classical beauty of our forms and our love." She shifts closer to his side as a couple passes them by, avoiding any sort of contact with them, and he moves ever so slightly to shield her body even more. "All the photos are supposed to be nods to classical piece of art."

"Which I know nothing about," Mydei says dryly.

She gives him a flat, unimpressed look.

"But I can still appreciate what he's doing."

"You better." She sniffs. "He's won several awards and grants for this work in particular. The Museum of Modern Art wants to exhibit him next year."

Mydei knows enough about the city's museums to know that's no small accomplishment. "That's… a big deal. Right?"

"It's a huge deal. Do you know how often living photographers are invited to exhibit there?" she asks.

His lips quirk. "No."

And her eyes roll. "Surely, you can guess."

"Infrequently?"

She gasps dramatically and then laughs into her fist. "Look at that, you're not just muscle and olive oil."

"At least, not today," he agrees, and they drift over to the next photograph and the next. Most of them are small, the sizes he would expect to see in a photobook, but when they turn the corner, he discovers wall after wall of photographs stretched across massive canvases that dwarf him. Powerful, life-sized subjects are rendered in exquisite detail and creamy shadows,

each piece possessed of a strangely ethereal quality, not that he could explain that quality if pressed. “They just don’t look like most photos,” he says lamely, frustrated by his inability to express what he’s seeing.

“It’s the camera,” a silver-haired young man says, approaching from Mydei’s opposite side.

Castorice’s lips turn up in a brilliant smile. “Phainon!” She releases Mydei, stepping back as though to give them space.

Bracing himself to deal with a melancholic and sanctimonious sort of art house asshole, the kind of man who eats cigarettes and drinks only black coffee, Mydei instead finds himself facing a man who looks like he just stepped off a gridiron. Tall and muscular beneath a leather jacket and printed tee, with piercing blue eyes, silvery hair, and a lopsided grin that’s far more endearing than it has any right to be.

He looks like Khaslana. Mydei swallows hard, taking in the similar features—the arch of his cheekbone, the curve of his jaw—and trying not to react. Mydei has met all of Khaslana’s family; he knows they’re not related, but they could be. Won’t it be fun to tell his therapist how he ran into Khaslana’s doppelganger.

If Phainon notices how rattled Mydei is, he doesn’t react. He offers Mydei his hand. “Nice to meet you…?” He trails off meaningfully.

“Mydei,” Mydei says, ignoring Castorice’s sly grin. He extends his hand, and Phainon takes it. His palm is warm, soft; his grip is strong, firm. Electric. Mydei can’t look away from those vibrant eyes. “A pleasure,” he manages, his tongue thick in his mouth. He forces himself to release Phainon’s hand, to step back, but he can’t look away. It’s not just that he looks like Khaslana, either. There’s a magnetism to Phainon that pulls Mydei in.

“All mine,” Phainon says. His gaze lingers, too, as though he’s just as arrested as Mydei. Then he nods toward the canvas hanging on the wall. “I use a large format camera,” he explains, which means nothing to Mydei, but he nods along anyway. Phainon’s excitement is contagious. “So I’m able to capture details more precisely, you could say, than with a standard thirty-five-millimeter sensor. The end result is something that feels surreal and subversive, and I wanted to capture that quality and juxtapose it against real, queer bodies and our concept of classical beauty.”

“You succeeded,” Mydei says, and it feels like such a stupid thing to say, but Phainon’s expression lights even more.

“You think so?”

He has no idea why his opinion might matter so much, but a not insignificant part of him is inordinately pleased that it does. Mydei turns to the photograph on the nearest wall, a lesbian couple standing at the base of a flight of stairs, nude, one bent over the other in a tender kiss. They are shrouded in shadow, doused in light, separate from their surroundings but still a part of them. “I’m not an artist,” Mydei says, deliberately ignoring how Castorice clears her throat delicately. “But I do. I think your work is…” He searches for the right word. “Decadent, but refined.”

Phainon gravitates closer to him, and the rest of the gallery falls away. “How do you mean?” he asks.

Mydei gestures to the photo, to the deep, luxurious shadows like so much chocolate poured over a dense torte. “The contrast of darkness and light, like two separate flavors that complement each other. The way form becomes a suggestion in a larger homage to what came before.” He glances at Phainon, surprised to find the other man watching him fixedly. “Decadent. But not overdone. Tasteful. So, refined.” He looks away, tense for some inexplicable reason, like he can’t bear to hear Phainon’s reaction to his fumbling explanation.

“Can you tell that to the critics?” Phainon asks.

“I’m pretty sure art critics are going to be able to explain that better than me,” Mydei says.

“They’ll be pretentious about it,” Phainon says, and Mydei allows himself another glance at Phainon, at the lopsided grin on his face. “And they’ll point out all my technical flaws, too.” He shrugs. “I’m sure you get that.”

Mydei laughs softly. “God forbid you undercook pasta.”

Phainon’s grin widens. “Yeah, exactly.” He nods at his photo. “Think of exposure—how much light is in the piece—as pasta, then. They’ll berate me for undercooking it. Too much shadow.” He shrugs. “But I like the effect.”

“To be fair,” Mydei says, “some people also like undercooked pasta.” He waits a minute. “But they’re objectively wrong.” He can’t remember the last time he spoke with someone like this. No, he can. Easy conversation, gentle banter with Khaslana. It’s as easy with Phainon as it was with him, and Mydei isn’t the type to get along with strangers easily.

Laughter spills out of Phainon, loud in the relative quiet of the gallery, but no one looks at the artist askance. It’s his show, and he can do what he wants, Mydei figures. “Are you saying my shadows are objectively wrong?”

Mydei’s lips twitch. “Undercooked, crunchy, and unseasoned.”

Phainon laughs again before nodding to another large photograph. “Can I get your take on that one, too?”

Mydei’s brows lift. “I can make a poor man’s attempt.”

“And I’ll be richer for it,” Phainon says easily.

Mydei doesn’t know quite what to do with that, and he turns to Castorice for help, acutely aware of how she’s been almost entirely cut out of this conversation.

She waves a dismissive hand. “I see another friend,” she says. “Come find me later.” She drifts away from them before he can gainsay her, before he can come up with anything subtle to keep her nearby. And then he’s alone with Phainon in the crowd, which he doesn’t particularly mind, it’s just that his palms are sweating again and he hasn’t felt like this, like his heart might beat out of his chest, in a year.

Mydei follows Castorice's retreat toward a blonde woman standing nearby. "She's the model from the kiss," he says of the blonde.

"Aglaea? Yeah." Phainon points out a few other individuals scattered around the room, naming them. "Most of my models are friends of mine, or friends of friends from the community." There's an assessing look in Phainon's eyes, measuring. "Have you ever modeled before?"

Barking out a laugh, Mydei shakes his head. "Hardly. I'm not photogenic."

That earns him a look of disbelief. "You're joking," Phainon says.

"I'd show you my selfies, but—" But he hasn't taken a new selfie in a year, and all the ones he has are of him and Khaslana. He swallows. "Trust me when I say they're bad."

Phainon takes a step back, and Mydei is suddenly wildly self-conscious. He cleans up well enough, and he knows he cleaned up well, with black slacks and a button up shirt and a bomber jacket that makes him look rougher than he is, but Phainon's gaze is that of a critical artist, not a casual passerby. "Selfies suck for most people because the focal length is garbage," he says.

With no idea what that means, Mydei says nothing.

"And most of us hate how we look in photos anyway," Phainon continues. "But." He glances away, as though suddenly bashful. "I've been wanting to do a series focusing on male models. I know it's a busy time of year, but if you're around, I'd like to work with you."

"I have no experience," Mydei says, lightheaded, heart pounding.

"Not a problem. I'm a great coach." Phainon's expression is warm and encouraging. "But no pressure if it makes you uncomfortable."

Mydei shakes his head. "It doesn't. I just wouldn't want to waste your time."

"Trust me: you wouldn't be wasting anything."

Something tremulous and sweet flutters low in Mydei's stomach. Phainon's polite insistence gives him the courage he needs to say, "Then, sure. I'll give it a try."

Chapter End Notes

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Two days later, Mydei gets a text from Phainon as he sweats on a midnight subway train. It's ten to twelve, he's exhausted from a rough dinner service at Pomegranate, and he's more than ready to climb into bed and sleep until ten. But then the notification pops up as he mindlessly scrolls the social media site du jour, and his heart is pounding, and his sweat has nothing to do with the heat and everything to do with nervous anxiety.

`I know it's pretty late, so if you're beat, just tell me to fuck off`, Phainon's text says. `I wanted to run the project by you since we didn't get a chance to talk about it at the gallery.`

Mydei's hands shake as much with exhaustion as excitement. They'd traded numbers right before another guest had stolen Phainon's attention, and Mydei hadn't wanted to text first. Hadn't wanted to insert himself, even with permission, into Phainon's life, despite desperately wanting to. With a sigh, Mydei rubs his thumb and forefinger into his eyes. He's being ridiculous, and he knows it, but it's been ages since he's even thought about being interested in someone else. He'd been so happy with Khaslana and then, after the crash, he just… didn't care. Now, he cares. It's exhilarating and terrifying, and he knows he needs to navigate this carefully because Phainon's being professional and Mydei feels like a kid with a crush.

`You've got me for another hour`, he texts back. Another twenty minutes to get home, and then forty to unwind and get to bed.

Phainon's reply is immediate. `Shouldn't take that long.`

Mydei kind of wants it to take that long, but that's him getting ahead of himself.

`Next project is about how men hold ourselves back. Hold everything in. Sort of the dichotomy of what we're feeling against what society expects us to show: nothing.`

That piques Mydei's curiosity. Society hasn't had a lot of space for him and his grief, forcing him to swallow his tears and his agony, to smile when he's wanted to break down. But just as much, he's put that pressure on himself. His therapist has asked him so many times why he hasn't cried when he's wanted to, and he's been forced to confront his own attitudes about masculinity and grief that haven't been comfortable.

Tentatively, he texts back. `I've got a lot of experience with that.`

`Is it okay if I ask how?` Phainon replies.

Mydei takes a deep breath, bracing himself, but the wave of tears doesn't come. Talking about Khaslana's death *has* gotten easier. My husband died a year ago. Car crash.

I'm sorry. Dots indicate that Phainon is still typing. I can't even imagine. If you don't want to participate anymore, I get it.

Mydei sits with that question for a minute as the train judders to a shaking stop and the doors screech open. The few other passengers stumble out, some drunk, most tired. The train lurches back into motion, and he rolls to his feet and moves to the door in preparation for his stop.

I'd still like to, he texts back.

Glad to hear it. At the risk of being too real with you, I'm excited to work with you.

The train slides to another rough stop, and Mydei slips out the doors before they're fully open, his heart beating faster than it should. There's no reason for Phainon to be excited about working with him, and that just—it tweaks him in the best way. He's excited, too. Terrified about his own inability to deliver what Phainon needs for the project, but excited.

Okay, next question: how comfortable are you with being mostly naked?

Mydei's foot slips on a stair, and he fumbles his phone as he catches himself. The only other person to get off with him gives him a wide berth, hurrying up the stairs ahead of him.

Really, the question isn't unexpected. All the models in Phainon's show were naked or covered only minimally with draping cloth. I'll live, he replies as he finishes his climb and passes through a turnstile. But I might be awkward about it at first.

A model's comfort is always my priority, Phainon sends. We'll figure out what works for you.

Cool air rushes over Mydei as he emerges from the subway onto the street. He glances up and down the mostly deserted street, clocking a few drunks emerging from one of the neighborhood's dive bars, and starts making his way back to his apartment, his phone tucked into his pocket. He lives in a nicer part of town and cuts a very imposing figure, but there's no reason to tempt fate. He doesn't pull his phone out until he's climbed the stairs to his third-floor condo, shouldered open the door, and stepped inside. He locks it behind him, sinking against it as he stares at his phone screen, at his text app.

Thanks, he finally replies. Then, Date and time?

He tucks his phone away as he toes off his shoes, shrugs out of his light jacket, and moves through his apartment. Late night silence envelops him, comforting. Used to be that the quiet bothered him; Khaslana would stay up to greet him, despite his own early mornings. Mydei still misses Khaslana's welcome, but the silence isn't a knife against his heart anymore.

One quick, efficient shower later, he falls into bed and plugs in his phone, popping open his texts to a string of replies from Phainon.

`Fridays and Saturdays are the day job.`

`Wedding photography pays the bills.`

`You own your own restaurant, so I assume evenings are out.`

`How about a Sunday afternoon?`

`2pm-ish?`

`Lets us recover from whatever happens on Saturday night.`

`Unless you have to work on Sunday night. Then maybe that's not so good.`

Grinning ruefully, Mydei types a quick reply. `Sunday afternoons work for me.`

He's not expecting an immediate reply, since it's pushing one in the morning, but Phainon surprises him. `Next Sunday, then?`

Mydei doesn't even check his calendar. The only thing he does on Sunday is sleep and read, recovering from his long week. `Next Sunday works.`

`I'll see you then,` Phainon replies.

Setting his phone down, Mydei rolls onto his back and stares up at the ceiling, his grin lingering on his lips. It's just a photoshoot, but, well, he hasn't met anyone in months. Hasn't really gone out at all, either. Castorice will be proud of him. So will his therapist. Hell, he's proud of him.

He's going to throw up.

Standing just outside the door to Phainon's studio, located in an old brick building on the edge of the arts and theater district, Mydei is so nervous that he's pretty sure he's going to throw up. Which is ridiculous—he's ridiculous—because this isn't a date. It's a job. He's doing a job for someone else. Sort of. Volunteering, really.

Raking a hand through his hair, he squares up to the door, inhales deeply, and knocks twice.

Phainon opens it a second later, a broad grin on his face. "Mydei!" he says, warm and effusive. "Come in, come in." He stands aside, letting Mydei into a sun-drenched corner unit with floor-to-ceiling Palladian windows. Even with all of Phainon's equipment—an assortment of backdrops, several boxy lights, a handful of cameras, and an assortment of old tables and chairs—the industrial studio feels spacious. Open. Welcoming.

Mydei relaxes as Phainon shuts the door, though he points at the windows that look into an office building across the street. “Please tell me you have blinds.”

Phainon laughs. “Not interested in giving the tech bros a show?”

“That’s just the kind of press my restaurant needs. Pomegranate’s head chef reveals all to unsuspecting board of investors at tech company.” Snickering, Mydei does a slow turn of the room, taking the whole place in, the backdrops, the equipment. His nerves come back in a rush, and he licks his lips, pivoting slowly toward Phainon. “Are you really sure you want to use someone completely inexperienced as a model?”

“Positive,” Phainon replies without hesitation. He crosses the studio space to the windows, pulling blinds down across them. “It’s your face,” he continues.

Mydei lifts a brow. “My face.” Which is flattering and weird all at once.

“No matter how I explain myself, I’m going to sound like a weirdo,” Phainon says, pulling away from the final window.

“Does it help if I tell you that you already do?”

“Touché.” Phainon approaches a large boxy light, reaching up to turn it on. A soft, white light floods the room. “It’s about the way your face catches light. The shapes of it. It’s interesting, and it’ll be even more interesting in black and white.” He fusses with the light, and Mydei wonders if he’s nervous, too, though he can’t imagine why he would be. “You can change out of your clothes behind the curtains there,” Phainon continues, pointing to a corner blocked by black curtains. “There’s a robe for you, too. Feel free to leave on your underwear if you want. I can probably work the lighting around it.”

Mydei inclines his head and ducks behind the heavy black curtain, leaving Phainon to his work, and strips out of his jacket, his shirt, his jeans. He hesitates over his underwear, his anxiety spiking. They’ve talked more about what’s going into this shoot—and just generally. Phainon’s made a concentrated attempt at conversation designed to make Mydei feel more comfortable. To build a rapport between them. It’s worked, yeah. He was attracted to Phainon before this, and for the past two days, he’s played with the idea of asking Phainon out for a coffee after all this. Depending on how it goes.

But now he’s in Phainon’s studio, and he has to admit that he barely knows the guy. That Castorice knows him—somehow—he’s still not sure how—goes a long way, sure, but that doesn’t make it easier to get mostly naked in front of him. In front of a relative stranger he’s attracted to. Shit. Worse: in front of a relative stranger he’s attracted to when he hasn’t been attracted to anyone in a year. Fuck. This is the first time he’ll be naked in front of someone who isn’t Khaslana in ages. But that doesn’t bring with it the host of anxieties that come with his general attraction, strangely enough.

He rubs his face as he stares down the robe, one thumb looped in the waistline of his boxers.

If he wants to ask Phainon out for coffee, he should be bold. Strip naked. But he can’t imagine his own embarrassment if he gets hard in the middle of the damn photoshoot. At

least if his boxers are on, he'll have the veil of decency. That's got to be an occupational hazard, though. Surely Phainon has seen plenty of uncontrolled hard-ons in this line of work.

Shit, he's taking way too much time to strip down. Phainon's probably wondering what's wrong with him, what's taking so long, and if he asks, then Mydei will have to come up with some asinine excuse to hide his cowardice. But Mydei isn't a coward.

He takes off his boxers, folds them neatly on top of his pants and shirt, and leaves them on the little table behind the curtain as he shrugs into the robe. Tying it loosely around his waist, he pushes the curtains aside and steps out to find the room lit in smokey shadows. Phainon has pulled down a simple backdrop of red and violet, and Phainon himself is at one of the old tables, rooting through a box of colored ropes.

Barefoot, Mydei approaches, curling his toes against the cool, concrete floor. "Usually, I make someone take me out for drinks before I let them tie me up," he says, hoping he doesn't sound as forced to Phainon as he does to himself.

Phainon snorts. "Better to do this kind of thing sober, anyway," he says casually, offhandedly, as if he's done this plenty of times. Well. Given the scope of this project, he has. He showed Mydei a handful of the photos he's already done, cleverly composited pieces of men bound and subdued with a screaming or crying or laughing face overlaid on a more neutral expression, ghostlike. Haunting. Beautiful. Mydei's never considered he might be beautiful before, isn't sure he'll be beautiful in these photos, but he's eager to see how they turn out regardless. "You've done shibari before?"

Clearing his throat, Mydei glances away. "No, actually."

"Do you get claustrophobic?" Phainon asks, setting aside several loops of rope. "I—" He finally looks up, his eyes catching on Mydei's tattoos. He exhales in a way that gets Mydei guarded.

"Are the tats a problem?" he asks, not sure how he's supposed to react to Phainon's observation.

Phainon studies his chest. "Is that all of them?"

Shrugging his arms out of the robe, he lets it fall around his waist, preserving his modesty but revealing the ink across his chest, his back, his arms. "This is," he says.

Abandoning his ropes, Phainon paces around Mydei in a slow circle. "Hm." Mydei's skin prickles with gooseflesh, and he holds himself almost painfully still under Phainon's gaze. "No… No, I think we can do some interesting rope work around them." He makes an amused little sound, something like a chuckle, as he returns to his table and his ropes. "This will be a fun challenge. But, back to my question: *are* you claustrophobic?"

Mydei shakes his head. "No."

"Good." Phainon hefts his ropes, looping them in the crook of his elbow. "Here's what I'm thinking: we do a harness around your chest and you lean forward on the tips of your toes so

you're hanging above the backdrop, here." He approaches the length of fabric spread across the floor. "I want your arms outstretched, so it looks like you're falling in the photos. If you're comfortable with it, we might tie your hair so your head is pulled back." He stands in the middle of the fabric, spreads his arms, tips back his head, and leans forward as much as he can without toppling over. "Like this." He hangs there for a minute and then beckons Mydei over. "But more dramatic. Sound okay?"

Sounds a little uncomfortable, but Mydei shrugs. He'll deal. "It's your vision, right?"

"There are other ways to accomplish my vision if you end up uncomfortable." Phainon throws several ropes over hooks Mydei hadn't noticed in the ceiling. "On the topic of discomfort." He catches the lower rung of a nearby stool and pulls it over, centering it on the fabric backdrop. "We'll keep you sitting as long as possible. The ropes will bite, and if it starts to hurt too much, we'll switch it up. To that end." He grins. "Same protocol as if we were doing a scene."

Mydei blinks. "A scene?"

And a flush rushes across Phainon's face. "Safe words," he says in a rush. "We'll use a safe word so if you're done-done, I'll know. Clearly. You know."

Mydei lifts a brow. He doesn't know, but. "Sure. Safe words."

"If you start to feel claustrophobic, if you're too uncomfortable, just say *chimera*. I'll let you down, untie you, and we'll take a break and try something else." Phainon looks everywhere but at Mydei as he explains. "Sound good?"

With a shrug, Mydei plunks himself down on the stool. "Sounds good," he says, a little amused by how gun shy Phainon has become. "Do you want me to take off the robe?"

Phainon turns redder still and clears his throat. "Keep it on for now so you don't get too cold. I'll, uh—" He clears his throat again. "I'll start with the harness around your chest, and we'll go from there."

Stiff, a little uncomfortable, Mydei folds his hands in his lap and waits, watching Phainon collect more rope from the table. A tense silence grows between them, increasingly weighty with each passing second, leaving Mydei restless. He's never been particularly good at sitting still, excelling in situations that demand all of his attention and then some—perhaps that's why he likes the kitchen as much as he does. Waiting for Phainon to get to work, to touch him, to bind him up in rope so he can't move, is… not necessarily unnerving, but it's filling him with the strangest anticipation. The silence isn't helping.

"How did you learn about this?" Mydei asks as Phainon approaches him.

Phainon hesitates as he stretches a length of rope between his hands. "Photography?"

A shake of Mydei's head. "No. The, uh, rope stuff." Fuck, but he's trying way too hard to force this conversation, and now he just sounds awkward.

“Ah.” Phainon gives a quiet chuckle, as if he’s nervous, too, as he lays the rope across Mydei’s shoulders, stepping into him, against him, close enough that Mydei can smell the clean, woodsy scent of his soap. “College, actually.” He clears his throat, passing the rough ends of the rope through the looped byte, securing it across Mydei’s chest. His fingertips are warm when they brush against Mydei’s skin, and Mydei fights against the urge to shiver. “Met an older guy who was into bondage, and he introduced me to the larger scene.”

“The larger scene?”

Phainon’s bright red again, which is a good look for him. “BDSM,” he says, clearly embarrassed.

“Like that book? *Fifty Shades of* something or whatever?” Mydei asks.

Phainon makes a comically pained sound in the back of his throat. “The actual scene is *nothing* like that.” He exhales heavily, his fingers drifting across Mydei’s back as he works. “But… kind of. I’ve always been fascinated by restraint. By how we hold ourselves back based on our own beliefs, on society’s beliefs, on what we owe to each other. The way clothing restricts us, and what its absence says. Rope work, shibari, bondage, it’s just a way to make all those invisible restrictions visible.”

There’s something soothing about how Phainon moves around Mydei. He’s slow, methodical, a heavy gravity that draws Mydei in. His fingers run beneath the ropes as though testing for something—tension, maybe—and the heat of them against Mydei’s skin leaves tingling in their wake.

“And there’s something… appealing, I guess, about holding someone back,” Phainon continues. “Beyond the photography and just the bondage itself, I mean. Tying someone up, restricting their movements… it’s not necessarily the control, though that’s part of it.” He ties a knot and tugs it a little harder than Mydei anticipates, causing him to lurch forward. Phainon catches him, a warm palm on his shoulder, and Mydei’s skin prickles. “Knowing that whoever I’m with has to take what I’m giving them is…” He hums as Mydei leans back, and Mydei catches the flick of his tongue over his lips.

Something syrupy spreads through him.

“Sorry,” Phainon says with a laugh. “That’s not super appropriate to talk about.”

“I don’t mind,” Mydei says, and he doesn’t. “It’s an interesting topic.”

“Yeah?” Phainon’s fingers ghost over one of the ropes, a phantom caress as he lays the dual lines flat against Mydei’s ribs, and Mydei suddenly wants Phainon’s hand directly on his skin.

Mydei inclines his head as much to nod as to follow Phainon’s motion around his body. The harness takes shape around him, constricting ropes tight across his chest when he inhales, and there’s something pleasant about that. Comforting, like a hug. “I’ve—like I said, I’ve never done anything like this.” He shifts his gaze to the far wall as Phainon steps behind him once more, his breathing slowing, deepening. “Or known anyone into bondage.”

“You probably did, but a lot of people are hesitant to disclose their kinks.” Phainon’s hand runs down Mydei’s spine, and then he tugs roughly on the ropes, pulling them tight in a way that catches Mydei’s breath and leaves him deliciously light-headed. “Maybe a little less so in openly queer communities, but it’s still there.”

Mydei leans forward in counterpoint to the way Phainon tugs him backwards, enjoying the way the ropes dig into his skin. They bite, but it’s a dull sort of biting, almost pleasant. “Not you, though.”

“Well.” Phainon grins as he comes around Mydei’s side. “My kinks are art.”

That earns a laugh from Mydei. “Isn’t all art just thinly veiled sexual perversion?”

“What’s that say about your food?”

Another laugh from Mydei as Phainon’s eyes sparkle with mischief. “Khaslana—my husband—suggested whipped cream in the bedroom once. I gave him a laundry list of reasons why that’s a terrible idea, and he never asked again.” Mydei’s own gaze softens. “But food is inherently sensual. Cooking for him was…” He shakes his head, a rueful smile on his face. How strange that this doesn’t hurt. “I loved cooking for him, but I loved watching him eat my food even more.”

“Food play isn’t really my thing,” Phainon says, pulling the rope across his ribs long and slow. “But feeding someone finger foods for dinner?”

The mental image floods Mydei’s imagination all at once. Candlelight and a bevvy of appetizers and small bites, all easily eaten with fingers. Him offering Phainon a bit of steak tartar on a thin cracker, and Phainon sucking his fingers between his lips as he eats. Phainon’s thumb rubbing across Mydei’s lips after he takes a bite of burrata, wiping away a bit of cheese before he leans close and takes Mydei’s lower lip between his teeth.

“It’s intimate,” Mydei says quietly.

“Extremely,” Phainon agrees, and for all the light flooding the studio, even with the blinds pulled, this moment feels intimate. Phainon stands at his side, knotting off a line of rope, and Mydei is naked under his robe, and Phainon’s hands are warm on his ribs and chest, and if Mydei turned his head, they might kiss.

He hasn’t thought about kissing someone in so long. But this isn’t a date, and that’s not why he’s here. This is a favor for a friend of a friend. He just really wishes it wasn’t that.

“Before we get you elevated,” Phainon says, speaking quietly, like they’re trading secrets. An electric frisson of something runs down Mydei’s spine. “I want to try something else. Do you mind?”

Mydei shakes his head. “Your studio, your project, your call.”

Phainon gives him a wry, lopsided grin that does wicked things to Mydei’s libido. “You can still say no,” he says, stepping away. Mydei wills himself not to react to the low and rich

timbre of his voice, but he knows that's a losing battle. It's not that Phainon reminds him of Khaslana—though that's certainly part of it—but more that Phainon has the kind of intensity and wit that has always captured Mydei's interest.

Breathing deep and coming up against the confines of the rope harness also captures Mydei's interest. Heat kindles low in his belly, a strange reaction to the bindings, but one he enjoys. There's a comfort in being contained like this. He can still move, still turn to watch Phainon go over to a nearby wardrobe, but the ropes hold him in a tight embrace, impossible to ignore.

Phainon pulls a plastic tub from the wardrobe, carrying it to one of his tables before opening it and reaching inside. He sets aside a bundle of cloth flowers, and Mydei's brows lift.

"Flowers?" he asks.

"Wedding photography," Phainon reminds him.

It's not a helpful reminder. "Sure, but why for this? This isn't a wedding shoot."

Phainon holds up a cluster of yellow and white flowers, squinting at them up close and then again at a distance, and Mydei wonders what he sees, what he assesses. "Did you know that every flower has a meaning associated with it?" he asks instead of answering Mydei's question.

"I know which ones are edible," Mydei replies dryly. "And those aren't."

"Well, they're cloth." Phainon grins as he approaches Mydei on the stool, a bunch of flowers gathered in his first. The grin fades into a contemplative expression. "I think…" He drops the flowers beside the stool, reaching for Mydei's arms.

Mydei gives them over easily, curious about Phainon's intentions.

Without any word of explanation, Phainon poses Mydei's arms—resting on the top of his head, elbows bent beside his head, arms stretched across his chest, cheek pillowed against his forearms. The silence this time is pleasant. Companionable. Mydei closes his eyes, letting Phainon do as he will and focusing on the gentle pull of Phainon's hands over his own, over his wrists.

"I'd like to tie your arms together," Phainon says. His voice is quiet, low. It washes over Mydei like a caress.

Mydei gives a little shrug. "Sure."

Warm fingers lower Mydei's arms to his lap before Phainon pulls away. Mydei doesn't open his eyes. There's a softness to the air, a strange and casual intimacy that he doesn't want to lose.

When Phainon returns, his fingers alight on Mydei's shoulder. "Here," he says, which is a kind thing to do, letting Mydei know he's returned. His fingers run down Mydei's arm, and more heat pools in Mydei's stomach, syrupy and sweet.

Mydei takes a slow breath through his nose, doing everything in his power to stay relaxed while willing his cock not to get hard and embarrass him.

Taking Mydei's wrists in his hands, Phainon lays one over the other. "Relax your hands," he says. The cadence of his voice has changed, though Mydei can't say how. Commanding but soft. Demanding but not unreasonable. Mydei obeys easily, willingly. "Good. Stay like this."

Rope pools in Mydei's lap, falling across his arms, and he shivers. It drags over his skin as Phainon wraps his wrists and then ties knots down the length of his forearms. When Mydei blinks his eyes open, he finds a knotted ladder binding his arms together in pleasing symmetry.

"I'm going to bind your arms in the position I want," Phainon says, lifting Mydei's arms beside his head. "That way you don't have to hold them up. Alright?"

Mydei makes a noncommittal sound, unbothered, as he closes his eyes once more.

Two fingers tap the back of one of his hands, expectant somehow. "Tell me, Mydei. Alright?" Phainon's sterner this time, and Mydei likes that.

"Alright," he says, letting the word sound a little begrudging just for the sake of it.

"Good," Phainon replies, and more heat washes through him.

As Phainon works, Mydei keeps his eyes closed, letting Phainon do as he will, floating in a strange mental space. All he has to do is what Phainon asks of him, which is a strange place to be in for him. Usually, he's the one making demands of his kitchen, though they've all worked together long enough that he doesn't need to bark orders. Still. He's the one in charge at Pomegranate. Here, with Phainon, he's not.

He exhales heavily, relaxing into the ropes, and finds his arms don't lower. At last, he opens his eyes, tipping his head back to find a line of rope extending above his head to a steel bar affixed to the ceiling. It keeps his arms raised beside his head, and that, too, is as strange a comfort as the ropes around his chest.

Phainon stands in front of him, flowers in hand once more, his expression thoughtful. He plucks one of the white blooms from the rest and slides its stem into one of his knots. With methodical precision, he decorates Mydei's bindings and then, almost absently, reaches out and applies a gentle pressure to the side of Mydei's head. Mydei moves as bidden, turning his face and leaning his head against his arms.

"Stay like that," Phainon says, the three words an inviolate command.

Mydei relaxes into the ropes and doesn't move as Phainon goes to his camera. He expected a bit of self-consciousness, but as Phainon picks up the camera and ducks behind it, Mydei is floating in a quiet sea of contentment. All he has to do is whatever Phainon asks, and that's so easy.

"Look over there for me," Phainon says, holding out one hand to point at a nearby chair.

Mydei looks.

The shutter clicks. The boxy lights burst with sudden light. Neither is enough to rouse Mydei from this strange stupor.

“That’s perfect, Mydei.” A soft pleasure washes through him. “You’ve really never modeled before?”

His tongue is thick, but he manages to move it enough to say, “Never.”

“Well, you’re doing great.”

He wants to make a joke about how he’s doing nothing more than hanging from the ceiling, but that seems like too much effort, and the praise is too nice to deflect. When friends and family and diners and critics praise his food, the compliments rarely stick. He’s not arrogant, but he knows he’s an excellent chef. These compliments, these kindnesses, land like caresses down his spine, his sides. More than anything, he wants to do better so he can get more of Phainon’s sweet words.

“Tip your head back? A little more… more… perfect.”

Another click, another flash of diffuse light. What a strange way to spend his Sunday afternoon, hanging from a ceiling, half-seated on a stool, tied up in front of a relative stranger and craving that stranger’s praise.

Phainon comes closer, and Mydei buzzes with awareness of his proximity, his skin prickling, electric sensation snapping through his nerves. As Phainon drifts around him, taking pictures at various angles, Mydei is content to lean into the ropes, letting them support him as much as the stool beneath him.

“Look directly at the camera,” Phainon says, his voice low, like the silence is something tender.

Mydei turns his eyes to the lens and then slightly beyond it, staring through the camera toward Phainon’s own eyes.

“Oh, perfect,” Phainon breathes.

His toes curl around one of the stool’s rungs, and he stays like that, floating, as Phainon takes his photos, obeying every time Phainon issues another instruction, until Phainon sets his camera down and approaches once more.

“Let’s try another pose.” Phainon tugs the rope stretching above Mydei’s head, releasing it. Mydei’s arms don’t drop suddenly. No, Phainon controls their descent, lowering them into his own waiting hand. “Flex your fingers for me.” Mydei does so, stretching them wide and then curling them into loose fists. “Any numbness or tingling?”

He shakes his head. “No,” he says, though it takes him a moment to find his tongue.

“Good.” Phainon’s thumb presses into one palm, and Mydei inhales deeply, sharply, catching a moan in the back of his throat and swallowing it back down. “Slide off the stool.”

Mydei does, stepping into Phainon’s body. There’s almost no space between them, and Phainon still holds his hands. “The robe,” he says, a little stupidly.

“Mind if I remove it?” Phainon asks.

Electric heat burns down Mydei’s spine and settles low in his belly. His cock twitches, and he should absolutely tell Phainon no, but he’s too languid and warm. “Sure, fine,” he says, trying his best to sound disaffected when he’s anything but.

Phainon’s thumb rubs a small circle against the soft skin of Mydei’s wrist, just above several lines of rope, and he reaches for the knot holding Mydei’s robe together. When he pulls it, it sags and gapes, and then Mydei’s entirely naked, too lethargic to even consider the danger of him getting hard.

“I want you to sit down on the backdrop,” Phainon says, canting his head to speak almost directly into Mydei’s ear. A full-bodied shudder pulls through him, and Mydei’s eyes drift shut. “Lean into me to keep your balance.”

Swaying forward, Mydei rests against Phainon’s shoulder and slowly drops to the floor. The fabric is cool, barely any protection from the concrete beneath, but he barely notices, too focused on how warm Phainon is. How he smells—fresh and clean and faintly floral.

“I’m going to untie your arms and rebind them in a slightly different position, alright?”

Mydei makes a quiet sound of affirmation.

“Tell me it’s alright, Mydei,” Phainon says, still rubbing Mydei’s wrist with his thumb. Mydei wishes he’d never stop. That single gesture melts every bone in his body; he can’t believe he’s still upright.

“’Salright,” he slurs.

“Open your eyes for me.” Mydei obeys, finding Phainon hovering close to him, a curious look in his eyes. “Do you remember the word I gave you earlier? For if you get uncomfortable with anything?”

They talked about a lot of words earlier, didn’t they? Mydei barely remembers walking into the studio, never mind a single word. Ah, no. No, he remembers. Safe words. They have one. “Chimera,” he says.

“Good.” The corners of Phainon’s eyes crinkle, and Mydei’s cock twitches again. He’s too out of it to be bothered. “You can close your eyes again.” Mydei does, and it takes everything in him not to moan as Phainon gently works the knots on his arms free, pulling rope along flesh in wicked caresses. “You’ve really never done any kind of bondage before?”

Mydei shakes his head. “Never.”

“Not even light restraint? Someone holding your arms down?”

A vivid memory of Khaslana doing just that blooms in his mind, his wrists pinned down by Khaslana’s hand, Khaslana hovering over him with a face so much like Phainon’s. But the memory doesn’t hurt, and this doesn’t feel like betrayal. How easy it is to imagine Khaslana telling him not to waste his life waiting around—especially when he’d said something so similar before Mydei opened Pomegranate. It’s been a year, and Mydei feels good. He feels so good in a way he hasn’t in a very long time.

“Once,” he admits. “My husband.”

Phainon makes a quiet, indecipherable sound. “We don’t have to talk about it.”

“I don’t mind,” Mydei says, and he doesn’t. This doesn’t hurt. “He held my wrists above my head sometimes, and that… always made it better.”

With the ropes on his arms undone, Phainon touches his knee. “Mind if I pose you?”

Mydei shakes his head. “No.”

Phainon’s warm hands curve around his body, pushing, pulling, but always gently. The fact that Mydei is completely naked in those hands barely registers. At Phainon’s coaxing, he bends one leg at the knee and sets his foot on the floor. His other is bent before him, foot hooked behind his ankle. He doesn’t feel at all exposed or vulnerable, just warm and floaty. Strangely content.

“Is that how it was for you?” Mydei asks, knowing he shouldn’t. They shouldn’t talk about sexual bondage while doing this, but he’s curious. He wants to know. “Being bound or held down makes it better?”

There’s soft laughter as Phainon begins wrapping rope around his upraised leg. “I prefer doing the rigging,” Phainon replies. “But, yeah. Seeing a partner tied up in my ropes, helpless, makes it better for me.”

“Why?” Mydei asks against his better judgment. He opens his eyes, watching, unfocused, as Phainon ties knots along his thigh, his calf. His cock is half hard, and he wonders how much better it would feel to have Phainon’s hands petting over his skin with the intent to arouse.

Phainon makes a thoughtful sound. “Control. Power. Taking away his ability to move away from my touch, forcing him—requiring him—to accept it. To accept anything I want to give.” Phainon’s voice is low and rough, and Mydei’s cock hardens more; he’s not the only one affected by this.

“You’re a control freak,” Mydei offers.

“Not as much as you’re thinking.” Phainon’s hands pull away from Mydei’s leg. One hand curves around his throat, and he lifts Mydei’s face, tipping it up and back, and Mydei swallows back an aching noise of need. “The exchange of power in BDSM is hot, but it’s

hotter to give my partner everything he wants. To glut him on pleasure until he's out of his mind with it."

Christ. Mydei wants to be out of his mind for Phainon—and no guilt accompanies that thought. It's been a year. Maybe his heart is finally ready for something new.

"Stay like this." Phainon rises and slips behind Mydei. He bends one of Mydei's arms up and back, resting Mydei's hand against his own shoulder blade. "Can you hold this position?"

Mydei takes a slow breath. "Yeah."

"Good." That word is another physical caress. Mydei's cock fills more, and he doesn't even care. He's too strung out on whatever this is. As Phainon ties Mydei's arm where he wants it, he says, "For me, it's also about holding, guarding, protecting my partner. My ropes aren't meant to hurt, though they'll bite if you struggle, but rather to embrace. To wrap them up in more of me."

"So, ownership."

Phainon's fingers linger as he works, dragging beneath the ropes to check tension. "Definitely ownership." His hand slides across the back of Mydei's neck and up. He takes a fistful of Mydei's hair, pulling Mydei's head back, and this time, Mydei can't swallow the quiet gasp soon enough. But Phainon doesn't comment on the sound, doesn't mock him or joke with him about it. "Stay like just like this, Mydei," he commands. When Mydei doesn't move, he breathes, "Good," and Mydei thinks he might combust.

Pulling away, Phainon rises. He collects more flowers and places each one carefully. Some, he feeds into the ropes that bind Mydei's body. Others, he piles around Mydei's knees and thighs, over his half-hard cock, in the spaces around his body. Mydei, floating, simply lets it happen. And when Phainon's knuckles brush his inner thigh in what has to be a deliberate caress, he doesn't try to smother the quiet sound of need he makes.

The world is soft and out of focus as Phainon takes his photos, the clicking shutter of his camera the only noise in the studio. Mydei's mind is empty, his thoughts quiet. Everything is so peaceful. No one's shouting over the raucous din of the kitchen, there's no frenetic energy as he works without break to prepare meals for hungry diners and fickle critics. He can't remember the last time he felt this serene, this peaceful.

Minutes pass in a hazy blur, marked only by Phainon's quiet direction. "Look here," he says. "Flex your arms—good. Over here, now. Perfect. You're doing great, Mydei." Every word of praise hums in Mydei's veins, effervescent and sweet, and he trembles not with the cold seeping up from the floor but from the heat coursing through him.

Finally, as his upraised arm begins to ache with exhaustion, Phainon sets his camera down and approaches. His hands are still warm as he undoes the knots on Mydei's arm, releasing him. Like before, he holds Mydei's arm as he lowers it. "Any tingling?" he asks, pressing his thumb into Mydei's palm.

Tongue heavy, Mydei struggles for words. "A little," he manages.

Phainon rubs his thumb over Mydei's fingers, and the faint tingling present in their tips recedes. "Let me know if it gets worse."

"Mm."

With gentle hands, Phainon removes the ropes on Mydei's legs, too. Every touch is slow and measured, lingering. Mydei imagines Phainon likes touching him, that he doesn't want to stop touching him, and a little sigh of pleasure slips past his lips. How wonderful it is to be touched like this again, to feel like this, like everything has fallen away and nothing matters but Phainon's hands.

"Mydei," Phainon says.

Focusing his gaze on Phainon takes tremendous effort, but Mydei manages. Phainon kneels before him, his hands resting lightly on Mydei's knees. He hasn't removed the harness.

"I want to ask you something, and I want you to be honest with me."

Lying seems far too complicated anyway, far beyond Mydei's current brain power, so he nods.

"Do you enjoy being tied up like this?" Phainon asks, looping a finger around a knot just below Mydei's sternum and tugging. That tug jolts pleasure down Mydei's spine, a pleasure that burns inside him. His cock, still half-hard, grows harder.

Any other time, he'd probably lie. Deflect. But everything is too soft, too quiet, too easy for him to even consider being untruthful. "Yeah," he says, meeting Phainon's gaze. Those blue eyes burn, intense. Fuck, but he doesn't want Phainon to look away from him. "Yeah, I do."

Phainon curls his fist around that knot, pulling Mydei closer to him, and Mydei is helpless to resist. Doesn't want to, anyway. "I want you to know," Phainon murmurs, his eyes drifting over Mydei's face and stilling on his lips. Mydei licks them. "I want you to know that I don't usually do this."

Doesn't do what—tie people up in his studio? That can't be true. Mydei's seen some of the other photos in this series. Phainon's done this with at least three other models so far.

"Do you want to come home with me?" Phainon asks.

Mydei's cock is fully hard, and he burns with arousal, with need. "Yeah," he says, too honest but incapable of being anything else. "Yeah, I do."

Rocking to his feet, Phainon pulls Mydei up by the harness, and that just gets him harder. Fabric flowers cascade off Mydei's body, piling on the floor around them, and Phainon draws Mydei closer. His free hand touches Mydei's jaw. With his thumb, he tips Mydei's head back. "Then I want you to get dressed for me, Mydei," Phainon says, bending toward Mydei until each word brushes their lips together. Mydei gasps, shivering. He doesn't know what to do with his hands, but his fingers flex with the sudden need to grab something, anything. He

settles on Phainon's elbows. "I want you to get dressed," Phainon says again, "and I want you to keep the harness on."

Chapter End Notes

forgot to mention this in the last chapter, but i plan to update on wednesdays and fridays until this fic is finished, and ch5 will have art!

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon's apartment is a torturous ten-minute walk from his studio. Beneath his shirt and jacket, the rope harness rubs over Mydei's chest and ribs. It squeezes when he breathes too deep, a phantom embrace, and the pressure of its bindings keep him on a strange edge. Though the distant haze from the studio fades on the street, his desire doesn't. Phainon makes sure of it. As they walk, he's free with his hands, touching the small of Mydei's back, brushing their knuckles together, curving his palm around Mydei's elbow to guide him around this corner or across that street. When they pause at intersections, Phainon leans over to murmur in Mydei's ear. Nothing crass, nothing erotic, just promises that they're almost at his apartment and that Mydei is doing so very good.

It's enough to have Mydei crawling out of his skin.

By the time the elevator doors in Phainon's building open, Mydei is so hard he hurts, and his underwear is sticking uncomfortably to his cock. He wants to tear off his own clothes, wants —

The doors close, and Phainon is on him, crowding him against one wall. Warm hands curve around his jaw and pull him into a wild, hungry kiss that he's utterly unprepared for. Yeah, sure, he knows Phainon wants him. Phainon wouldn't have invited him over if that wasn't the case. But he isn't expecting Phainon's teeth on his lower lip, hands strong on his jaw, hips pressed flush together, hard cocks grinding against each other through clothes.

Mydei gasps, grabbing at Phainon's wrists, and Phainon takes that as an invitation, dipping his tongue between Mydei's lips. It's a hard kiss, a needy one. Phainon's tongue fucks into his mouth in a blatant mimicry of sex, and Mydei groans, arching into Phainon's body. The ropes suddenly feel too tight, like he can't breathe, but instead of triggering anything like anxiety, the sensation serves only to make him harder, hotter, hungrier. He rocks his hips against Phainon's, and pleasure dances through his veins, little electric jolts that have him panting into Phainon's mouth.

One of Phainon's hands catches Mydei's chin, and he turns Mydei's head to bite gently on his earlobe. "I'm going to take you apart," he says, a promise and a threat, and Mydei groans, head falling back, back arching, his cock rubbing hard against Phainon's own.

The elevator comes to a smooth stop, and Phainon all but drags Mydei out by his wrist, pulling him down the hall with no small amount of urgency. He presses his phone to the lock on his door, opens it, and the two of them fall inside.

Phainon has him against the door a second later, phone tossed on a nearby shelf, hands on Mydei's hips. His mouth finds Mydei's throat around the collar of his jacket, nipping and biting at his skin as Mydei, reeling, grabs hold of Phainon's shoulders for any semblance of

mooring. He doesn't find it, can't find it, not when Phainon abruptly pushes his hands beneath Mydei's shirt, shoving it up the length of his stomach, his chest.

Without thinking, Mydei shrugs out of his jacket and then lifts his arms, letting Phainon yank his shirt over his head. Then Phainon's hand wraps around a knot in the harness and he pulls Mydei forward roughly, pulls Mydei into his body.

"You look so good in my ropes," Phainon breathes before taking Mydei's mouth again.

Mydei drives one hand into Phainon's hair, holding him close as they kiss. There's no soft haze anymore, only a burning hunger that drives him against Phainon's body, deeper into his embrace. Phainon's tongue is in his mouth again, slick and demanding, tangling around Mydei's own. Fuck but this feels good. Being wanted, desired, feels so fucking good.

Without breaking their kiss, Phainon walks them backwards, deeper into the small apartment. Mydei gets glimpses of it when they come apart for brief, gasping moments—a tiny galley kitchen, a closet of a living room, and then they're in a bedroom dominated by a modest bed just big enough for them both. Phainon drags Mydei onto the bed, onto him, before rolling them over. He climbs onto his knees astride Mydei's hips, a wild look in his eyes.

"Fuck," he says, his fingers still clutching at the ropes of Mydei's harness. "You look—" He exhales a breathless laugh and removes his own jacket, his light sweater, the white tee beneath it.

Mydei, a little stunned to find them both half naked, stares up at Phainon, his heart hammering in his chest. Phainon is just as cut as he is, impossibly well formed, like some ancient Greek statue come to life. There's a golden sun tattoo on the side of his neck, and a thick scar runs down the center of his chest, large enough and pink enough to give him pause.

"Are you—?"

"Ask me again another time," Phainon says, and that's enough to deter Mydei, because in the afternoon light, Phainon is gorgeous. Unspeakably, perfectly gorgeous, with the kind of body Mydei has always fantasized about. Big, maybe bigger than him—big enough to overpower him, to hold him down. A moan slips out of him, and Phainon thumbs his lower lip. "To be in that head of yours," he murmurs, reaching for his belt, his pants. He slides off the bed to remove them, stripping out of his underwear in the same motion, and Mydei props himself up to stare unabashedly at his body.

Even Phainon's cock is big. Long, thick—enough to worry Mydei briefly. He hasn't had sex in a year, and that cock is going to be a challenge, but Mydei isn't one to back down from challenges.

"Back up," Phainon says, reaching for his cock and stroking it once, twice.

Mydei swallows, his own cock aching in his sweatpants. He wants to get his mouth on Phainon's cock more than he wants to breathe. But he backs up the bed anyway, falling against the two pillows at the head of it. One of his hands drives into his hair as he lays there, panting. Then the bed dips as Phainon climbs onto it.

“How do you feel about oral?” he asks in a tone that suggests it’s not a question. In a tone that suggests he’s not just going to want oral sex but that he’s going to want to fuck Mydei’s throat.

Mydei arches off the bed. He shoves at his sweatpants, pushing them down his hips and kicking them off so he can fist his cock, squeezing the base of it as pleasure hammers through him. “Yes,” he manages.

Chuckling, Phainon straddles Mydei’s shoulders. “Not what I asked,” he says. Mydei’s pretty sure that’s wrong, but he doesn’t care, because Phainon’s cock is close enough for him to get his mouth on it. Releasing himself, he pushes onto his elbows and parts his lips. Phainon slips a hand into his hair, cradling the back of his head. “But I like the enthusiasm. You’re so good, Mydei.” Another shudder runs through Mydei, and his cock throbs against his thigh. “Go on, then. Suck my cock.”

Through the heavy fall of his lashes, Mydei looks up at Phainon, at the intense need in his eyes and the heat burning within them. His tongue drags along the length of Phainon’s cock, and they both groan. Phainon’s head falls forward as Mydei’s eyes flutter shut, as he licks Phainon a second time, a third. He takes hold of the base of Phainon’s cock, guiding the tip toward his mouth as he flicks his tongue against the liquid beaded there. Salty, bitter. Perfection. Fuck, he’d almost forgotten how good precum can taste when he’s half out of his mind with need.

He pulls his tongue over the tip of Phainon’s cock again. Swirls it around the crown. Parts his lips more and eases Phainon’s cock into his mouth. Phainon makes a quiet sound, aching and needy, but doesn’t thrust deeper. How polite.

Smoothing his hand across Phainon’s toned hip, Mydei urges him forward. Slowly, Phainon sinks his cock into Mydei’s mouth, and Mydei groans, letting his eyes drift shut so he can focus on *feeling*—the stretch of his lips, the weight of Phainon’s cock, the taste of Phainon’s skin, the clean-soap smell of him. Precum drips onto his tongue, and Mydei shifts restlessly beneath Phainon, gripping his hips hard. He wants to take himself in hand, wants to stroke himself as he sucks Phainon off, but if he does that, he’ll come, and he doesn’t want to come so soon.

Mouth wrapped around Phainon’s cock, Mydei sucks in a slow, even rhythm, pulling Phainon deeper and then letting him slip out, almost to the tip. The easy back and forth of it lulls him into a strange serenity, not so different from the haziness of their studio time. He’s floating on a sea of burning pleasure, basting in the ache of his own want.

“That’s it,” Phainon breathes. “Fuck, your mouth feels so good.” Phainon, still cradling the back of Mydei’s head, lifts him. He shifts forward, rolling his hips, and his cock slides over Mydei’s tongue, the tip of it nudging the back of his throat, and Mydei moans.

Oh, but he loves this, loves when someone takes his mouth, uses him. And Phainon *is* using him, is moving in harder thrusts, faster ones, ones that push deeper into Mydei’s throat.

“Mydei, Mydei, you’re so hot.” Pleasure simmers in Mydei’s veins. “Be good and—fuck.” Phainon groans deeply, pushing halfway down Mydei’s throat, and Mydei can’t stop the

whine that spills out of him. “Be good and hold onto the headboard for me.”

Too out of it to do anything but obey, Mydei lifts his hands from Phainon’s hips and grips the arch of the wooden headboard, clutching it in his fingers. Beneath his fingers, the wood is a cool counterpoint to the burn of his own body.

Phainon’s fingers fist in Mydei’s hair, and Mydei jolts, Mydei groans, Mydei arches off the bed and skates his legs wide, desperate for more. Phainon pulls gently, adjusting the angle of Mydei’s head and neck. “Perfect, you’re perfect. I can’t—I can’t hold back, not anymore,” Phainon says, and that’s Mydei’s only warning before Phainon starts a quick, brutal pace, thrusting hard down his throat.

It’s good, it’s so fucking good, it’s everything Mydei never knew he wanted. He grips the headboard harder, gasping, tears leaking from the corners of his eyes as Phainon slides deeper, deeper, choking him, forcing him to inhale sharply through his nose. He can’t catch his breath. Dizzy, lightheaded, he rolls his hips against nothing, desperate for a friction that simply isn’t there, as Phainon takes and takes. And Phainon is whining softly, has one hand braced on the headboard beside Mydei’s, is leaning over him.

“Can’t stop,” Phainon gasps as Mydei sucks around his cock, pulling it even deeper, urging it further down his throat. “Feels too good to stop.”

Some distant part of Mydei’s barely functioning brain considers that this can’t feel that good if Phainon’s still capable of speech, so he redoubles his efforts. He suckles deep when Phainon pulls back and relaxes his throat to take everything Phainon wants to give when he thrusts back in. Having Phainon’s cock buried in his throat is uncomfortable in the best way, choking off all his air, soaking his temples with tears and his lips and chin with saliva. There’s a buzzing in his ears—he needs a deep breath but he doesn’t want to take it, doesn’t want to release the strong suction of his lips around Phainon’s cock. And Phainon is whining again, is groaning, is working his hips harder as his abdomen brushes against Mydei’s nose, and that’s the hottest thing Mydei’s done or felt in a year, having Phainon this deep inside him and, fuck, Phainon’s going to be deeper inside him still. He wants to grab at Phainon, to hold onto him, but he’s been told to hold onto the headboard, and that dichotomy, the need to obey and restrain himself against his own desires, cuts like the sharpest knife. His cock aches, throbbing between his legs, and he moans, and Phainon moans, too.

“Close, so close, don’t stop, don’t stop,” Phainon says, his words a breathless chant.

Mydei doesn’t stop, doesn’t breathe, just sucks Phainon harder, deeper, until Phainon thrusts deep and cum spills down Mydei’s throat. He swallows it down, drinking it like it’s the finest wine, desperate for more, and Phainon pours into him, drips cum across his tongue. When he pulls away, it’s to bend over Mydei even more, to take his chin in hand and then kiss him savagely, plunging his tongue deep into Mydei’s mouth. He licks over Mydei’s tongue, tasting every inch of him, and Mydei groans, squeezing down on the headboard as he fights the desire to grab Phainon, to cling to him.

Forcing Mydei’s head down, Phainon breaks their kiss and leans back. His eyes are glassy and he’s panting, but he’s far from blissed out. No, that intense expression is still all over his

face, feral and borderline inhuman. Mydei shudders, lips parting on a silent gasp. Not even Khaslana was this intense with him, but he likes it. He likes it so very much.

“I’m going to fuck you,” Phainon says, his lips brushing over Mydei’s. “I’m going to fuck you until you can’t think. Until you can’t walk.”

Mydei swallows; dirty talk like this usually does nothing for him, but the intensity in Phainon’s gaze… he believes him. And that does something wicked to his insides, twisting him up in the most delicious way.

Phainon eases off Mydei’s chest and shoulders, kneeling beside him. “Roll over,” he says, leaving no room for disagreement. Mydei lets go of the headboard and rolls onto his stomach, groaning when Phainon runs his fingers down the length of his spine, over the lines of rope. Fingers catch around one knot near the base of the harness, tugging sharply. “Head down, on your knees. Spread your legs.”

A shudder goes through him as Mydei obeys, pulling his knees under his body to lift his ass. Like this, he’s vulnerable in his nakedness in a way he wasn’t in the studio. Exposed, he trembles, his fingers gripping the comforter beneath him even as more pleasure and desire simmers within him. This is good, it’s so good, to be wanted feels exquisite, like perfectly searing a cut of meat so that it melts in his mouth.

Phainon’s mouth touches the curve of his ass. Teeth dig into his flesh, a lingering bite that shocks him. He jumps, tensing, then forces himself to relax. Precum drips from his cock onto the bed beneath him as Phainon mouths across his skin, as Phainon urges his legs just a little wider.

“Pretty,” Phainon says, almost absently, as he pulls his thumb over Mydei’s hole.

Mydei’s cock twitches, and he buries his face in the pillow under him, his toes curling.

Warm breath gusts over Mydei’s ass. He has half a second to realize what Phainon’s about to do before wet heat pulls over his hole. Phainon licks over him, across him, pushes his tongue inside him, devours him with a grip on his hips that affords him no freedom. And when Mydei’s hips start to jerk as if to escape Phainon’s attentions, Phainon grabs hold of the harness with one hand and takes Mydei’s cock in the other.

Mydei makes a hysterical sound, smothered by the pillow. He makes another as Phainon pulls on the harness, lifting his chest off the bed, suspending him over it as Phainon continues to lick him and begins to stroke him, too. The ropes biting into his skin should be painful. Instead, they’re like a citrusy garnish: sharp and crisp, magnifying the sweet heat of Phainon’s tongue and hand. Mydei can’t breathe for the pleasure, for the way Phainon’s hand pulls down his cock in time to the lapping of his tongue. Phainon’s thumb pulls over the tip of his cock, smearing precum into his skin before he resumes his steady stroking, pushing Mydei closer and closer to the edge of an orgasm that Mydei still doesn’t want.

“Not yet,” he manages, all but pleading. “Want—want you inside me when I come.”

Breathless laughter washes across Mydei's ass. Phainon's teeth sink into his flesh, just enough to pinch, before Phainon says, "That's not for you to decide."

That lights Mydei up like a fucking flambé. He jerks in Phainon's hold, straining against the harness for more, for less, to escape the relentless pleasure Phainon gives him. But he can't escape, and that's—that's so fucking *good* that his brain just stops functioning. Cogent thought evaporates as Phainon tongues him, strokes him, squeezes around him, hand moving faster, faster, until Mydei is rocking into Phainon's fist. His body vibrates with pleasure, his toes curling, his breath coming in harsh pants. Every pull of Phainon's tongue and hand shove him to the edge of that wicked cliff and though he tries to find safe purchase, tries to stave off his own pleasure, he can't.

Mydei comes with a muffled cry with Phainon's tongue flicking inside him, with saliva dripping down his ass. He comes with Phainon's hand wrapped around him, squeezing him, coaxing more and more cum out of him. Shuddering, gasping, he spills onto the comforter in aching bursts, his cock so sensitive that he hurts. But what a good hurt it is, a delicious burn, another perfect accompaniment to the pleasure coursing through him.

When he sags against the bed, all his weight on the harness in Phainon's grip, Phainon pulls back. He leans over Mydei, one hand between Mydei's shoulder blades, pushing him deep into the bed. Mydei groans, boneless, and watches as Phainon reaches into his nightstand drawer and removes a small bottle of lube. Before he pulls away, Phainon bends to touch his lips to Mydei's ear. "Watching you come got me hard again, Mydei," he murmurs, his voice low and rough. "Want to be inside you. Want to carve into you. Fuck you. You're going to be so good."

A pathetic sound catches in Mydei's throat. He will. He will be so, so good for Phainon.

Then Phainon is kneeling behind him, is uncapping the bottle, is pouring lube over Mydei's hole in a trickling stream. A finger pushes against Mydei's hole, playing at penetration, and Mydei, still drugged on his orgasm, reaches back to open himself even more for Phainon.

"So good," Phainon breathes, and Mydei's spent cock, slick with his cum, twitches between his legs. "Can't wait to get into you. Can't—fuck, I want—" He trails off as his finger circles Mydei's hole once, twice, and then pushes slowly, relentlessly, into Mydei's ass.

On the heels of his orgasm, Mydei is soft and pliant. It's been a year, but he's so relaxed that Phainon's in him to the second knuckle in an easy glide. And, fuck, that feels better than his first Michelin star. That feels—he's full and stretched just the smallest bit, the pressure against his rim like the finest wine.

Phainon makes a choked, broken sound, easing his finger back only to thrust it back in, slow and lazy. He takes his time, and Mydei doesn't protest, just lets Phainon do as he will. He's too drunk on ecstasy to complain, to demand more, even though he wants it. Now that he's got one finger in him, he wants more. He wants Phainon's cock. Fuck, he wants to be so full he feels it in his throat, wants to choke on it, wants to choke on Phainon again. He groans, fingers digging into the meat of his ass.

A second finger pushes into him, the stretchy burn of it more decadent than the richest cabernet sauvignon. With both those fingers deep inside him, his vision is cloudy and unfocused, all his attention on how they open wide to stretch him before pressing down, down, down until—

He cries out, clutching at the sheets with his free hand.

Phainon leans over him, mouth finding his ear once again. “Feel good?” he asks, panting.

Mydei tries to muster a response but can’t manage anything more than a low, aching moan as Phainon plays over his prostate a second time, a third. The easy pressure of it has Mydei melting into the bed, has his cock twitching back to life. He’s always been a one and done sort of guy, but he’s not about to complain about the pleasure tingling through him. It’s a little painful, a little uncomfortable, but it’s everything he wants, and he embraces it even as he struggles to escape it.

“No,” Phainon says, pressing harder on Mydei’s prostate. “No, you’re in *my* bed. You’re with *me*. You’re *mine*, Mydei.”

Fuck if that doesn’t have him half hard in the span of a heartbeat. Pleasure burns in his belly, at the base of his spine. It’s thick and syrupy, a caramelized sauce that he can taste on his tongue as Phainon continues to fuck into him with his fingers.

Drawing back, Phainon takes one of Mydei’s wrists in his hand. “Here,” he says, pressing it to the small of Mydei’s back. He holds on for just long enough to make his point before letting go and taking Mydei’s other wrist, bringing it to the small of Mydei’s back, too. There, he gathers both wrists in one hand, squeezing hard as his fingers work in and out of Mydei’s ass, and Mydei, delirious, keens almost senselessly. He flexes against Phainon’s hold, testing it, and Phainon responds by gripping him harder. There’s no breaking free, and that takes Mydei from half hard to fully erect. It takes everything in him not to drop his hips to the bed and rut against it, to fuck against the comforter in search of relief for the pleasure building inside him once more.

More. *More*. This isn’t enough, and he groans, he whines, he rubs his cheek against the pillow as if that will give him some peace as he arches his back and helps Phainon fuck him open.

“Needy,” Phainon says. “Do you need my cock in you?”

Mydei offers a broken sound in place of spoken affirmation.

“Gonna fuck you so good. You’re gonna be so *tight* around my cock. Need to—need to open you up, need to—”

“Fuck me,” Mydei gasps, forcing the words out.

Now Phainon makes a broken noise. “Not yet, not yet, you’re not ready, you’re too tight. I—”

"*Fuck me*," Mydei says again, growling the words, arching his back and skating his knees wide.

Phainon's fingers pull out of him. A hand cracks against his ass once, and he jumps, but that stinging pain only heightens his pleasure—a pleasure that threatens to burst a moment later as the blunt head of Phainon's cock pushes against his hole. "Can't help myself," Phainon mutters. "Can't help myself. Have to—have to have you. You're so—you're *good*, Mydei, you're—"

With no leverage, Mydei can't do anything but take the slow intrusion. Phainon's cock eases into him, stretching him painfully wide. He should've let Phainon do more prep, should've let Phainon open him up even more, but he's too desperate for it, and the burning sort of pain feels incredible. The pressure, the fullness, it's all so fucking *good* as Phainon carves into him inch by perfect fucking inch.

"Should've… should've finished… tight, you're so *tight*, I'm—" Phainon's babbling, and Mydei doesn't care. Mydei barely notices. Nothing matters except the exquisite length of Phainon's cock filling his ass, stretching him to his very limit as he bottoms out, as he leans over Mydei's back, nails scraping over Mydei's skin as he grasps the harness. "So hot," Phainon breathes. "So hot, so tight, so perfect for me, you're perfect for me."

Mydei preens, rubbing his cheek against the pillow and opening his eyes to gaze over his shoulder. Phainon looms over him from behind, haloed by the afternoon sun, a fucking vision.

"Breathe," Phainon says, his hand tightening on Mydei's wrists.

It's the only warning Mydei gets before Phainon pulls out and slams back into him. He doesn't breathe. He can't. He chokes on his air, on the way Phainon's cock pushes so deep he can feel it in his guts. His body forms around Phainon, squeezing and clenching down on him, and they both moan.

Phainon is merciless. He takes Mydei hard and fast, ruthlessly pounding into him as he grips Mydei's wrists tighter and tighter, as he twists his fist around the harness until it bites into Mydei's chest and shoulders. It's a wild, brutal ride, and Mydei can't do anything but go along with it—not that he's opposed to that. No, he's on fire, burning with ecstasy, as Phainon fucks groans of pleasure out of him.

To be bound, to be held down, to be contained by someone else is better than anything Mydei's ever had, and he's delirious, he's out of his mind, he can't fathom sex any other way than just like this, again and again. This is so exquisite it borders on the divine. No matter what he does, how he flexes and strains, he can't break free of Phainon's hold, and Phainon's ropes are even stronger than Phainon's grip.

For a brief moment, Phainon's rhythm falters, but only so that he can adjust himself. And then when he thrusts back into Mydei's body, his cock hits Mydei's prostate over and over, the sensation enough to have Mydei wanting to crawl out of his own skin. Good, so good, good enough that tears spill from his eyes and cut down his cheeks, and he's pleading for

Phainon to stop, to let him go, to give him some kind of mercy. Phainon doesn't. If anything, he redoubles his efforts, fucking harder into Mydei's body.

The relentless rhythm of Phainon's cock against his prostate is too much. His cock twitches and jerks and he comes again, burying his face in the pillow and sobbing Phainon's name as his body seizes with pleasure. His orgasm is a long, drawn out affair, his fingers clenching and releasing as he struggles against Phainon's superior hold.

Behind him, Phainon croons with pleasure. "Good, good," he murmurs. "Mydei, that's so fucking *good*, you're so *good*. You're taking me so well. Look at you, you're perfect, you're perfect." He yanks Mydei onto his cock, into his thrusts, driving deeper, deeper, until his own rhythm falters, until warmth floods Mydei and Phainon releases him to bend over his back and rest his forehead on Mydei's shoulder with a long, pleased exhalation.

Mydei's legs, trembling, give out. He collapses to the bed, and Phainon follows him down. His cock slips out of Mydei's well-used hole, and he replaces it with the tip of one finger, rubbing against Mydei's rim.

"How good you were," he says, pushing that finger into Mydei's ass. Mydei makes a weak noise at the back of his throat. "So full of my cum."

Oh, but that does wicked things to Mydei's insides. He's exhausted, he's shaking, but his cock twitches in a way he would appreciate at any other moment.

"Mydei, Mydei." Phainon settles against his side, brushing a lock of Mydei's hair from his face. Mydei turns to him and finds a serene smile on his face. "How do you feel?" he asks.

Still not wholly attached to his body, Mydei only grunts. He rolls to his back, draping an arm over his face and letting out a gusty sigh. Already, there's a pulling in his thighs that tells him he's going to feel this tomorrow. But other than that, he feels… boneless. Exhausted. Wonderful. "Good," he finally says. He drags his arm away from his face, looking at Phainon again. "Do you do this often? Invite models back to your place?" There's no meanness or accusation in his voice, just curiosity, and Phainon takes the question with a lopsided grin.

"Never," he says. "You're the first."

Instead of making Mydei feel special, that yanks him hard into the confines of his flesh. He frowns. "Why, then?"

Phainon's grin softens. "There's something in BDSM called subspace. The submissive partner sort of… disconnects from reality. Everything gets a little fuzzy around the edges."

"Huh." Mydei turns his gaze to the ceiling, resting his hands on his stomach. There's a wet spot under his ass that's rapidly cooling and growing extremely uncomfortable, but he doesn't move.

"You hit that during our shoot."

He's not about to deny the truth. "Yeah."

“So, I went out on a limb and invited you back.” Phainon pushes himself up, sitting on the edge of the bed. “Probably should’ve done that when you were in a clearer frame of mind, but I—”

“No,” Mydei says. “It’s fine. That was…” He exhales, closing his eyes. “Good. Really good.”

Phainon rises, and Mydei’s impressed he can walk. He’s pretty sure he’s going to melt right into the bed beneath him. His legs may never work again. “Good,” Phainon says. “Why don’t you ooze out of bed and into the shower? I’ll order us some pizza or something.”

Mydei cringes. “Not Rick’s,” he says.

Startled, Phainon stares at him. “But Rick’s is the best chain in the city.”

“Rick’s is cheap slop that uses premade, frozen Prego as pizza sauce. Absolutely fucking not,” Mydei replies.

Phainon bursts out laughing.

“So, let me get this straight,” Castorice says, three days later, as they sip coffee at the only table in a new shop the approximate size of a broom closet. “You’re feeling guilty because you’re not feeling guilty enough about sleeping with Phainon?”

Mydei rubs his thumb and index finger into his temples. “When you put it that way, it sounds stupid.”

“It’s not exactly stupid,” Castorice says slowly, drawing out the words in a way that says it really is stupid but she doesn’t want to be that direct. “This is the first time you’ve been with someone since…” She gestures. “Everything.”

Mydei drops his hand and stares into his cup. The cappuccino is fine—good, even—but he barely tastes it. He hasn’t tasted anything, really, since Sunday because he’s been so damn preoccupied. “Shouldn’t it feel like I’m betraying his memory?”

She grimaces. “Maybe if you’d slept with half the city?”

He gives her a look. Her grimace turns into a small smile. “Grief is a strange thing,” she says softly, her eyes going distant. “And it’s different for you than it is for me. No one can ever occupy the same place in my life Polyxia did, but you can find another man to love and be your husband.”

Mydei looks away. “I… feel like I should feel like I’m replacing him.” He rubs at his face. “But I don’t feel that way.”

“Then maybe it’s the right time. Maybe Phainon’s the right person. This doesn’t have to *be* something, anyway. You had sex with him once.”

They had sex several times throughout the afternoon and into the evening, actually, and Mydei had only left because he had shit to do on Monday morning before going to

Pomegranate. Castorice doesn't need to know that.

"We have plans for this weekend," Mydei says.

Her brows lift. "Do you want it to be something?"

"Maybe?" He takes a sip of his coffee to give him time to mull over the question. "I don't know." With a quiet sigh, he sets his coffee back down. "Everything was so sudden. He didn't get to tell me it's okay to move on, but I… I want someone in my life again. And I don't feel bad about that when maybe I should."

"For what it's worth, I think you're allowed to feel however you want about it."

"You sound like my therapist."

Castorice grins. "Your therapist must be smart, then." She sobers, softens. "But seriously, Mydei. You don't have to feel bad about wanting someone new after a year. You've been processing this whole time and working through your grief already. It makes sense that you wouldn't feel bad about this. I think you're just looking for permission to feel the way you do, and you don't need that from me."

His eyes narrow. "That's too on the nose."

Holding up both hands, she laughs. "Oh, no, I'm so sorry I won't let you shove your head in the sand and feel bad for yourself."

"You're the worst. I don't know why we're friends."

Her lips curve. "Well, if we *weren't* friends, you wouldn't have met Phainon to begin with."

"Are you really trying to take credit for this?" he asks dryly.

She brushes a lock of hair over her shoulder, preening. "I'm going to take *all* the credit for this, especially if it goes well."

Chapter End Notes

poor mydei, feeling guilty about being ready to move on :< grief is a funny thing

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They see each other every Sunday, when Pomegranate is closed. During the rest of the week, they text constantly, a non-stop stream until Mydei steps into his kitchen and then they resume when his work is done. Mydei expects their texts to be explicit and sexually charged, and they are—late one Wednesday, they send increasingly explicit photos to each other until Phainon just texts `Call me` and Mydei does. They jerk off on the phone at one in the morning.

But Phainon also asks him how his shifts are. Phainon invites him to complain about his coworkers when he needs to, gives advice when asked for it, shares his own woes when Mydei invites that, too. Free time for both of them is a limited commodity—Phainon begins installing his work at the Museum of Modern Art, and Mydei only has Sundays off—but they talk whenever they can, call whenever they can, spend time together whenever they can. Their dates are silly things, really: they run errands together before Mydei's shifts, when Phainon is free, too; they meet up for hastily devoured dinners at convenient bodegas; they ride the subway together whenever they're headed in a similar direction, meeting up at stations and hopping into train cars to sit together.

`My schedule has always been a point of contention with previous partners,` Mydei tells Phainon.

`Even your husband?` Phainon is always respectful, but he's curious, too, and Mydei doesn't begrudge him that.

`Even him. He'd wait up for me at night, but I know it wore on him. Make me a promise, Phainon.`

The reply is immediate. `Anything.`

`Tell me when it's wearing on you,` Mydei replies, heart hammering.

A heart appears on the text bubble, and Mydei swallows hard.

`I'll tell you,` Phainon promises. `But I see you trying. I see you making time. That's enough.`

Mydei does make time. For the first time in more than a year, he leaves his kitchen in his sous chef Hephaestion's command so he can go to the opening of Phainon's exhibit at the Museum of Modern Art. He doesn't check his phone once throughout the event. It's Phainon's shining evening, and Mydei refuses to check out for even a second. Pomegranate will be fine. He starts taking slower nights away from Pomegranate, too—Tuesdays become another off day, and on Wednesdays he leaves early, trusting the kitchen to his extremely

skilled and qualified staff. Those nights, he spends at Phainon's, tapping himself into the building and the unit itself with his phone. Phainon has added him to the security app.

Inviting Phainon to his own place is harder. It's inviting Phainon into a space that he shared with Khaslana for nearly three years, and while three years isn't an eternity, it still feels like some small slice of one. Phainon never pushes, never asks why they don't go to Mydei's, and that's what gives Mydei the courage to have him over, to let him stay the night, two months into their relationship.

They make pancakes for dinner, dabbing batter on each other's noses, making a mess in Mydei's kitchen, blaspheming the sanctity of his church, but he finds he doesn't mind, especially not when Phainon lifts him onto the counter, steps between his legs, and kisses him slowly, softly, thoroughly until his toes curls and his breath comes in sharp, hot pants. They don't have sex that night but rather lay tangled in each other's arms in the bed Mydei once shared with Khaslana. He's still there, Khaslana, a presence hovering at the edge of the room, and it's harder than Mydei realized it would be to share this with someone else.

"Would you tell me about him?" Phainon asks in the darkness.

So, Mydei does. How they met—when Khaslana was in college and Mydei was working as a server in a fast casual restaurant chain that has long gone out of business. Mydei wrote his own number on the goddamn check, and Khaslana had texted him that same night. How he realized he was in love—Khaslana cooked his favorite meal for his birthday, and it had been terrible, but Khaslana had *tried*, and it had been so incredibly sweet. How they got engaged. Their wedding. Milestone moments that Mydei still remembers with such clarity.

"Is this too weird?" he asks when he realizes he's been talking for at least forty minutes.

"No," Phainon says, tucking Mydei close, curving around him like a bastion against the world. "I asked. I want to know. He's important to you—" Is, is, is, and that tells Mydei everything he needs to know about Phainon. "—and he always will be. I want to respect that."

Mydei swallows. "Does this… do you…" He groans, wanting to pull away. He doesn't. Tucking himself against Phainon's chest, he covers his face with one hand, even though it's too dark for Phainon to see his face anyway. "I don't want you to feel like… like there's some sort of… I don't know, some ranking between you. Like you're fighting his memory." He swears. "This is stupid."

"It's not, and I don't." Phainon noses into Mydei's hair, holding him a little tighter. He swallows, and Mydei knows he has more to say.

"What is it?"

Phainon makes a dismissive noise.

"No, Phainon." Mydei bullies him to his back, leaning over him. "Something's bothering you. Don't you always tell me how important communication is?"

Phainon looks away, clearing his throat. “It is. Important.”

“Then are you a coward?”

And Phainon’s head whips back around, his eyes narrowed. “No,” he says, vehement. Then, softer, “No. No, it’s just… It doesn’t feel like a competition, but sometimes… sometimes it does feel like I’m intruding. On what you had.”

That punches straight through Mydei’s chest. “You’re not,” he says, but he knows that won’t be enough.

“I am.” Phainon wraps his hand around Mydei’s the one on his shoulder. “All the things you’ve done before with Khaslana, the special things, like Pomegranate and being here. This place, your home.”

Oh, but Mydei hates this, and he hates it more because he doesn’t know how to fix it. “I’m—I didn’t mean to make you feel that way,” he says, because he doesn’t know what else to say.

“It’s mostly my problem, anyway,” Phainon says with forced cheer.

Mydei scowls at him. “If we’re together—”

“We are,” Phainon says too quickly.

“—then it’s my problem, too. You’re not intruding. I want you here. Do you really think I’d have invited you here if I thought you were intruding?” Mydei shoves lightly at Phainon’s shoulder. “Don’t be stupid.”

Choking on a laugh, Phainon squeezes Mydei’s hand. “And here I’m pouring out my heart to you.”

Mydei’s eyes catch on that scar, the one that runs down Phainon’s chest, less angry now than it was the first time they were together, but still red at the edges.

“Not tonight,” Phainon says, his laughter fading. “No ghosts tonight.” And then he grins. “Except the obvious one.”

But rather than the reminder of Khaslana hurting and dampening the mood, Mydei grins, too. “Maybe I should get a ouija board and we can ask him his opinion of you.”

“I’m sure he’d hate me,” Phainon replies dryly.

Mydei isn’t so sure. They wouldn’t have gotten along, their intense personalities too similar; they probably would’ve butted heads. A lot. But he thinks there would’ve been respect between them. “He always said I had the superior taste between us.” Mydei eases down, tucking himself against Phainon’s side and laying his hand over the scar on Phainon’s chest. “I think he’d come around.”

In the morning, they brave the cooler fall weather for a pumpkin patch and cider mill outside of the city. They get lost in the corn maze and bicker over whose fault that is (Phainon’s,

clearly) before finally making it back to the farmhouse to drink hot cider and eat overpriced caramel apples. Mydei makes them go through the pumpkin patch, picking out a pair of large, fresh pumpkins he can use to make sweet, fall treats for himself and Phainon—and for the small party Aglaea is hosting the day before Halloween. Pumpkin bars and rolls, a small tart. They don't dress in matching costumes, but everyone knows they're together, and that lightens Mydei's heart. Warms it. People know, and they're happy for him, for them.

The weather turns colder. A brutal winter storm dumps three feet of snow on the city overnight, shutting everything down. As other people attempt to dig out of their homes, Mydei snuggles into Phainon's, cozy and content—despite the fact that Phainon's kitchen, even now, contains only a single skillet and nothing beyond salt and pepper for spices. As more snow falls outside, undoing the hard work of plows and shovels, Mydei lays against Phainon's chest. They're watching some terrible Christmas movie—something about a big city journalist returning to her small town for the holidays—because Phainon is addicted to them, but Mydei isn't paying much attention. His fingers brush over the bottom edge of that scar that runs down Phainon's chest. He frowns.

"I almost died," Phainon says abruptly, reaching for the remote and pausing the movie. "I—sorry. That was… sorry. I'm just… bad at talking about it."

Mydei tips his head back, looking up at Phainon as Phainon looks down at him, their noses brushing. "What happened?"

"I was born," Phainon replies with a dry, unpleasant laugh. He leans his head back against the couch, closing his eyes and looping his arm around Mydei's hip, drawing him closer. Exhaling heavily, he continues. "I was born with a heart defect, a bad valve. It was okay when I was younger, but became problematic as I got older, so it got replaced. But it fucked up the rest of my heart, I guess."

Mydei presses his hand to Phainon's sternum. "How?"

"The stress of compensating for the bad valve." Phainon shrugs, wrapping his hand around Mydei's. "Medication managed everything for a while, but it got worse and worse, to the point where the whole thing had to go."

Mydei sucks in a sharp breath.

"That was… what? Eighteen months ago?" He shakes his head. "Feels like longer. I got lucky there was a donor match." He squeezes Mydei's hand gently in his own. "But a lot of the time I just think that my luck was someone else's grief. Not that I'm not happy to be alive. I am. It just came at the cost of someone else, so I don't… I don't really like talking about it."

Mydei doesn't know what to say to any of that. "That's… a lot to deal with," he says at last. "I… fuck, that was insipid."

Shaking his head, Phainon presses a kiss to Mydei's forehead. "It's not."

"Don't spare me. It was."

He laughs. “Maybe a little. But I appreciate it anyway. It *is* a lot.” He lapses into silence, resting his cheek against Mydei’s head. “I wrote a letter when I was recovering,” he says abruptly, his voice lower, quieter, like this is some kind of secret. Maybe it is. “To the family. I—I never sent it.”

Mydei’s thumb rubs over the clean edge of Phainon’s scar. “You’re not usually a coward,” he says, not unkindly. Gently, rather—or as gently as he can.

“No, but, really, what do you say to someone to make that okay? ‘Sorry your loved one died, but I’m alive, so yay for me’ or something?” Phainon scoffs.

Rearing back, Mydei gives Phainon a look. “Well, sure, if you said that, you’d be an asshole.”

“That’s my point.”

“And mine is that you wouldn’t say something like that.” Mydei settles astride Phainon’s lap, and Phainon’s hands ease over his hips. “You’re not a dick.” Phainon grins, tugging Mydei against him, and opens his mouth. “Shut up,” Mydei says before Phainon can say something stupid. “Look, Phainon.” He slides his fingers along the curves of Phainon’s shoulders and into his hair; he was never interested in the movie, and he’s even less interested in it now that he’s on Phainon’s lap. “If it were me, I’d want to know. If Khaslana saved someone like that…” He offers a lopsided smile. “One last piece of good. I’d want to know.”

“I’ll think about it,” Phainon says before lifting his face for kisses that start slow and sweet before turning hot and desperate and needy.

The city digs itself out of the snow over the next two days. Pomegranate reopens, and Mydei returns to his kitchen. Dinner service isn’t strained, but he is, and he doesn’t know why. He spends the first three hours short-tempered and irritable with the increasingly urgent desire to go to his phone.

Last time he felt like this, Khaslana—

Phainon is spending the night in, but that doesn’t mean he might not go somewhere. Or Castorice, maybe, could be visiting friends. Anxiety curdles his tastebuds and sours his stomach to the point where he can no longer bear it, and when he steps away from his current dish, he calls out that he’s taking a breather. No one questions him.

Slipping out of the kitchen, he goes directly for his locker, whips open the door, and digs out his phone. A handful of irrelevant notifications slide across his screen, but nothing from an unknown number that suggests someone is in trouble. Sighing heavily, annoyed with himself, he clears them—until his eyes catch on his emails. His thumb hovers over the notifications. That top-level notification. That’s from the hospital that tried to save Khaslana’s life. And the subject line is—

An Important Message from…

Nausea twists his stomach. He taps the notification. His eyes skip over the rest of the subject line and drop to the body of the email.

Please find enclosed below a message from the recipient of Mr. Khaslana's heart—

He stumbles backwards. His back hits the wall, and he slides down it, dropping to the floor hard enough to rattle his teeth. Now isn't the time. Dinner service is in full swing.

He can't tear his eyes away.

Hello, the letter begins. *I should start with an apology for how overdue this letter is. I'm sorry. Your loved one's life saved mine, and I didn't know how to thank you. I didn't know what to say, and I've rewritten this letter so many times. "Thank you" isn't enough. It doesn't encompass all your grief or all my relief.*

Mydei stares at the phone, hot and cold and numb all at the same time. He can't feel floor beneath him or the wall behind him. His hands shake.

I'd been sick for a while. Since I was born, actually. About a year and a half ago, I started getting sicker. I started to die. One day I was dying, and then the doctors said there was a heart for me, and then I wasn't dying anymore. It was surreal.

This is surreal, this moment.

Because of your loved one, I got to see my artwork on display in a museum I've gone to all my life. Because of your loved one, I got to watch two of my best friends get married.

Mydei's heart lurches. His breath catches.

Because of your loved one, I got to meet the man I want to marry.

No. No, the dread and the certainty and the terror are wrong, and he's hoping, he's hoping so much that when he scrolls down, but he already knows, he—

Words don't come easy to me, but I hope this letter can bring you some comfort, even though it's so very late. I'm sorry for that. Your loved one saved my life, and words cannot express my gratitude.

Sincerely,

Phainon

Mydei's phone slips out of his fingers. He presses his face into his hands, and he weeps.

Chapter End Notes

I PROMISE THERE'S A HAPPY ENDING!! don't let this penultimate chapter deceive you!! it's very emotional, but!! /points to the happy ending tag

next wednesday is our final chapter along with art!

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Someone must have called Castorice, because she's suddenly there in the breakroom, hurrying up to him with a stark expression on her face. He's in shock still, trembling still, and he looks up at her, stares at her, doesn't know what to do with her.

"What happened?" she asks.

He looks at the phone on the table beside him. Numb, he picks it up, pulls up the email, and then slides the phone across the table to her.

She reads the email, silent, only to suck in a long breath of shock and disbelief. "Oh, Mydei." She comes to a stop in front of him, her hands clasped before her. "What a terrible shock."

That's an understatement.

"I don't know what I'm supposed to do," he says, staring blankly at the floor between them. "What am I—Castorice, he has Khaslana's heart."

She makes a soft, wounded sound. "I know," she says, and nothing else, but he doesn't need her to say anything more, not yet. There's nothing to be said, anyway. Phainon has Khaslana's heart, and Mydei can't figure out how to feel about it. Here, at last, this thing has ripped open the old wound of Khaslana's passing, letting it bleed freely, and he's not sure how to staunch it this time. Is worried he might not be able to.

Beyond the breakroom, the noise of dinner service continues, the clanging of pots and pans and the calling out of orders and requests for ingredients. He should be there, with his staff, but when Hephaestion found him and moved him to the breakroom, it was with instructions to get his shit and go. He can't even manage to do that. Has been sitting here for at least thirty minutes.

"Does knowing change anything?" Castorice asks, so softly, so kindly, as though she knows how fragile he is. Maybe she does.

He looks up at her, gaze still blank but focusing slowly. "What?"

"Does it change anything? Knowing that Phainon has Khaslana's heart?"

"Yes," he says, immediately. But then he thinks about it—actually thinks about it—and, well, maybe it doesn't. Nothing could have saved Khaslana's life, the internal damage too much for the doctors to fix; he'd died in the ambulance on the way to the hospital.

Phainon receiving Khaslana's heart didn't kill him, the crash did. But Khaslana's death prevented another one. *One last piece of good*. Khaslana's death saved Phainon's life. *One last piece of good*. Khaslana's death was a terrible thing, but, in some strange way, it gave

him Phainon. It gave him a second chance at love. The fact that Khaslana's heart beats in Phainon's chest doesn't change how he feels about Phainon.

One last piece of good leading to so much *more* good.

"No," he says softly. "It's not as if Phainon killed him." He swallows hard and turns his gaze to his hands, hanging between his legs as he hunches forward. His lips quirk, a sad attempt at a smile that fades quickly. "He saved Phainon." And he presses his hand to his face as tears burn in his eyes. "Christ, Castorice, I've—I've been so lonely."

"I know," she says, still soft and kind.

"But I haven't—I can't—" The breakdown he thought he'd have after sleeping with Phainon for the first time is hitting now, all at once, two months of feelings he probably should've addressed sooner. He grinds the heels of his hands into his eyes. "His death gave me Phainon. You—you gave me—"

She makes a soothing little sound. "I might have helped," she says, a smile in her voice. "But you did the work. You pursued that relationship and built it into what it is now." Dragging his hands down his face, he looks at her, at the small, encouraging smile on her face. "Maybe Khaslana really did give you Phainon."

Mydei makes a choked sound, his throat convulsing, his body shaking. "I have to tell him. Don't I?"

"You do," she agrees. "But you don't have to tell him tonight."

He shakes his head. "I do. If I put him off, he'll know something is wrong. I can't do that to him." He closes his eyes. "I'll… go over to his place, maybe. Explain. He'll probably want space. Or something. But I… I have to tell him."

"Do you want me to go over with you? Just to his apartment."

Another shake of his head. "No. No, I need to this myself." He offers her a small, grateful smile. "But thank you. You didn't have to come here tonight."

She tuts. "Of course I did."

"You didn't. But you did. Castorice, you've… you're an amazing friend, and I know I haven't been the best one to you."

"Nonsense."

He holds up a hand. She's saying that to be polite, and they both know it. "Ever since we met," he says, "you've been giving more to me than I ever did to you." That awful night, she'd found him sobbing in the hospital, and she sat with him, saying little but offering him the comfort no one else had been there to give. "Thank you. Really. For everything."

With the softest, gentlest smile, she shakes her head. "Go talk to Phainon," she says.

And he swallows, hard, suddenly paralyzed. “What if he reacts badly? What if he’s freaked out or he doesn’t want to see me again? What if—”

She hushes him. “Phainon’s not like that. He adores you.”

“But I—”

“Mydei.” She glances meaningfully at his phone. “He said he wants to marry you. Maybe he’ll need some time to process this, but I don’t think it’s going to change how he feels.”

Mydei reaches for his phone, needing to hide it. For the first time in his life, he’s— “I’m scared,” he admits, clutching his phone in his hands. “That this will change everything.”

“Then he isn’t the man we thought he was,” she says. “And it will hurt, but you will move past it. But I don’t think that will happen.”

He looks at her, hopeful. “No?”

“No. I think you were always meant to love this heart.”

Mydei doesn’t send Phainon a text asking if they can talk, but Can I come over? might not be much better. He realizes that as soon as he hits send, but he doesn’t know how to follow up. He can’t say it’s nothing serious, because it is serious. He can’t say nothing’s wrong, because, well, something is wrong. Kind of. *Wrong* isn’t the right way to describe it, but he doesn’t have something better. Maybe it’s that something is *different*, but that’ll be lost in text, and he briefly debates calling Phainon, but then they’ll just have this conversation over the phone, and he doesn’t want that, either.

`Of course,` comes Phainon’s reply when Mydei is already on the train. `What’s wrong? What happened?`

Mydei stares at the texts for a long time, wondering how he’s supposed to respond. `It’s hard to explain over text,` he finally sends back, which is terrible, which is going to freak Phainon out, and he knows it, but he doesn’t know how to say any of this better. `But we’re okay,` he adds, because he can’t say it’s not about them when it is.

`Now I’m nervous,` Phainon replies, and Mydei’s stomach sinks.

Instead of saying anything else, he dodges. `I’ll be there in twenty.`

`Okay` is all he gets back, which doesn’t bode well for him.

He swears softly as the train takes a sharp turn and jostles him against the people on either side.

By the time he gets to Phainon’s, he’s sweating under his coat. He knocks on the door as a warning before tapping himself inside, and Phainon’s halfway to the door, wearing a hoodie and flannel pants, dressed for bed already. There’s another terrible Christmas movie paused on the tv screen behind him.

“Hey,” he says as Mydei shucks his coat and climbs out of his boots. “What’s going on? Is everything okay?”

Shit, he doesn’t know how to answer that question because it’s up to Phainon, really, if things are okay. “I got some… weird news today,” Mydei says, tossing his coat on the counter, which is only going to drive Phainon crazy, but Phainon barely looks at it.

“What’s that mean?” Phainon asks, visibly uncomfortable, fidgeting back and forth, his hands tucked into the pocket of his hoodie. “Mydei, why’re you acting like this?”

“I got your letter,” Mydei blurts out, because he doesn’t know what else to say, and this is the worst way to say it, standing in the tiny foyer next to Phainon’s galley kitchen, him still dressed for work and Phainon in his pajamas.

Phainon just stares at him. “What letter?” He laughs, but it’s an awkward, disquieted sound. “What are you talking about?”

“Your letter,” Mydei says again. “About your heart.” Phainon’s face goes white. “To the donor family.” Phainon isn’t fidgeting anymore. “I got your letter,” he says, quiet. Almost defeated. Scared, really, since he has no idea how Phainon is going to react, but Phainon’s expression—pale and wide-eyed and disbelieving—isn’t boding well.

Swaying, Phainon grabs the counter and sags against it. “That’s not—that’s not possible,” he says, staring blankly at Mydei.

“Yeah,” Mydei says. “It is. Khaslana died eighteen months ago. Your heart transplant was—” Phainon shakes his head. “—eighteen months ago. You said… you said you were sorry. For taking so long.”

Phainon’s expression is wild, his eyes red and bright with unshed tears. One hand covers his mouth.

“But that because of Khaslana, you got to exhibit at the Museum of Modern Art.”

“Shit,” Phainon breathes, dropping his hand.

“You said you wanted to marry me.”

“*Shit*. I—that letter—” A thin, hysterical sound catches in his throat. “That letter was for someone else.” He sounds lost, so very lost. “Not for you. Mydei, that letter wasn’t meant for you.”

Mydei offers him a lopsided smile. “Well,” he says, since he doesn’t know what else to say. He glances at the couch behind them. “Maybe we should sit down?” He approaches Phainon slowly, reaching out, and is relieved when Phainon lets him take his hand. Warm fingers wrap around his—Phainon is always so warm—and he tugs Phainon away from the counter and over to the couch. They ease onto it, Mydei turning off the movie, and Phainon just stares at him, shellshocked.

“It wasn’t meant for you,” Phainon says again. “That letter was supposed to go to someone else.”

Mydei’s chest tightens. For a moment, he can’t breathe. Then the anxiety eases, and he exhales, pulling Phainon close to him, against his chest. “But it didn’t,” he says, draping an arm around Phainon’s shoulders.

For a long, silent moment, they just sit like that, Phainon leaning against Mydei, his expression stark, and Mydei curling around him, protecting him and the heart he carries within him.

“Is this too much?” Phainon asks at last. “Knowing that I’ve got his—Khaslana. That I’ve got Khaslana’s heart. Is it too much?”

Mydei exhales heavily, closing his eyes and leaning his cheek against Phainon’s head. “I don’t know,” he admits. “It *is* a lot. But too much? I really don’t know. Not yet.” He pauses, then ventures, “What about for you?” Because this isn’t just about him. It’s about both of them.

“He saved my life.” Phainon tucks himself closer to Mydei. “The fact that it’s *his* heart…” He trails off. Tenses.

“Coward,” Mydei says, teasing, without heat, opening his eyes to let them wander the room.

Phainon laughs. “Maybe. I don’t want to say the wrong thing.” Which is fair, Mydei thinks, because he could. They both could. The is a tender, fragile moment, both of them on edge, and one wrong word could ruin everything. It’s terrifying. “It makes me feel closer to you,” Phainon murmurs. “Having his heart.”

Mydei’s breath catches. *I think you were always meant to love this heart*.

“But that’s weird, and I—”

“It’s not weird,” Mydei tells him, giving him a squeeze, and Phainon looks up at him, eyes bright and full of vulnerability. “Promise. It’s not weird at all.” He rests his forehead against Phainon’s. “Do you want me to go? So you can, I don’t know, process all of this?” He finds himself suddenly on Phainon’s chest, tucked against him, as Phainon sprawls on the couch beneath him.

Warm arms wrap around his waist. “Don’t go,” Phainon says. “Please. I—don’t go.”

“I won’t,” Mydei says, a promise. He tucks his head beneath Phainon’s chin and rests one hand over his sternum, feeling the steady beat of his heart—of Khaslana’s heart—and tears burn in his eyes. Renewed grief, yes, but also something like relief. “I wouldn’t have you if not for this heart.”

“Yeah.” The word is quiet, subdued. Then Phainon laughs, the sound soft and ragged. “I wouldn’t be here. I wouldn’t have you, either.”

Mydei rubs his thumb along the center of Phainon's chest. He can't feel the scar beneath the thick fabric of his hoodie, but he knows it's there.

They stay like that for a long time, until they start to doze. Mydei's the one who bullies Phainon into bed, knowing they'll both be miserable come morning if they sleep on each other on the couch. Climbing into bed is a little awkward, both of them hesitant, both of them on opposite sides of the bed until their fingers, seeking, brush against each other, and then they're tucked close, clinging as though they can't bear to let go. Mydei doesn't think he'll fall asleep like this, but he does. His sleep is deep and dreamless, and when he wakes, it's to the smell of something burning. Of food burning.

Jolting upright, he finds himself halfway out of bed before he realizes Phainon isn't there, either. His sluggish brain does the math: Phainon's in the kitchen, Phainon's cooking breakfast, Phainon's burning breakfast. Wearing pajama pants he'd left on a previous occasion, he stumbles into the kitchen, still bleary-eyed, and finds Phainon frowning over his stovetop.

"What're you doing?" he asks, rubbing at one eye.

Phainon sighs heavily, giving Mydei a world-weary look. "Well," he says, "I was trying to cook you breakfast."

"Why?" Mydei asks, because it's too early for him to be polite and they both know Phainon isn't the world's most gifted chef.

At that, Phainon balks a little, shrugging up his shoulders and leaning away—and, fuck, the whole place is starting to smell like burned batter as he turns off the stovetop. "After last night, I thought it would be nice." He passes Mydei a mug of coffee, cool enough to drink but still hot, and Mydei closes his hands around it. Takes a sip. Starts to feel human, slowly, as he shrugs off the vestiges of slumber and starts inhabiting his own skin again.

"You're burning pancakes," Mydei says dryly, bumping Phainon out of the way with his hip.

Phainon sputters. "I wanted to do something nice for you!"

"Ah, yes, so you nearly ruin breakfast, forcing me to take over when I'm barely awake—"

"You're more of a morning person than I am," Phainon protests.

Mydei shoots him a glare. "You're the most morning person I know," he says, looking meaningfully at the sun tattooed on Phainon's neck.

"That's not what that means and you know it."

"Mm-hm." Mydei sets his coffee down, turns the stovetop back on, slaps butter in the pan, and gets to work.

Phainon slips behind him, resting his chin on Mydei's shoulder and his hands on Mydei's hips. "Why're you being so mean to me?" he asks, a pout in his voice.

“Someone has to humble you,” Mydei drawls.

“I’m plenty humble,” Phainon protests.

Scoffing, Mydei eases backwards, fitting his ass into the cradle of Phainon’s hips where Phainon is half hard already. “You’re the least humble man I’ve ever met.” Which isn’t true, but it’s fun to tease him, and, oh, nothing has changed. Nothing has changed between them at all, as Phainon needles him back, pinching his sides and biting at his neck until Mydei turns off the stovetop once more and twists around and drapes his arms over Phainon’s shoulders, and then they’re kissing slow and sweet.

Phainon backs him against the counter as he sips lazy kisses from Mydei’s lips, as they grind against each other, and nothing has changed at all.

I think you were always meant to love this heart.

Mydei thinks Castorice was right. “Phainon,” he says between suckling kisses. Phainon gives him no space to say anything else, slipping his tongue back into Mydei’s mouth, forcing Mydei to bully him back. “Phainon,” he says, more emphatic.

“What?” Phainon asks, staring at Mydei’s mouth, his hips still moving in lazy undulations against Mydei’s. “Can it wait? I wanna—” He leans in, biting at Mydei’s lips.

Groaning, laughing, annoyed and pleased and more than a little turned on, Mydei turns his face away. “You stupid—I’m trying—I want to tell you that I love you, Phainon, for fuck’s sake.”

Phainon goes still, his lips against Mydei’s neck. “You do?”

“You’re an idiot,” Mydei replies, and then Phainon swings him into his arms and carries him back to the bedroom, where they fall into Phainon’s bed and Phainon whispers words of love into every curve of Mydei’s body.

Snow spins lazily down from fat, grey clouds, dense in the overcast sky. It’ll pick up later, according to the forecasts, and dump another foot of snow on the city overnight, but for now everything is coated in a layer of soft powder, ephemeral and quiet. Castorice walks along a sidewalk, weaving her way through crowds and banks of snow piled high on the edges of the road.

Ahead of her, Mydei and Phainon walk down the same sidewalk, hand in hand. She’s far enough back that they don’t notice her, but even if they turn around, they won’t see her. Not this time. She’s not here for them, after all.

They step into a doorway and then into a building with a large front-facing window, the words *Harbor Gallery* painted on it. Just before it stands a lone man, peering through the window. He is dressed for the cold weather, wearing a hat and scarf and thick jacket. He isn’t an unassuming sort of man, possessed as he is of a strange and intense presence, but Mydei and Phainon didn’t even acknowledge him. Not even a wave or a nod in his direction.

Castorice joins him at the window. “What do you think?” she asks.

“That I can’t believe this took a year,” he says, though not unkindly. He speaks with fondness, with great nostalgia and kindness. “But he always was like this. Loyal. Stubborn.”

“He was. He is.” She makes a thoughtful noise. “Are you happy, now?”

“Hm. Happy.” Together, they watch Mydei and Phainon greet friends with hugs. Beyond them, massive photographs of men in black and white hang from the walls. “I think I am.”

“Then, are you finally ready to rest?” she asks, holding out her bare hand to him. Unlike the man, she wears little to protect her from the cold, only a gown of white and purple, but she doesn’t feel the chill.

He slips his hand in hers, the illusion of his winterwear disappearing. His hand has no weight, no temperature, no texture. He looks once more into the gallery, where Phainon talks animatedly about a photograph of a man who is clearly Mydei, and he smiles. “Yeah,” he says. “I am.”

“Goodnight, Khaslana,” she says to him as his form dissipates, as he transforms into a kaleidoscope of violet and indigo butterflies, glittering like so many amethysts.

Beyond the window, Phainon abruptly stops talking. He turns toward the window, toward Castorice, a frown on his face. For a moment, his eyes catch Castorice’s, and, as though reflexively, he touches a hand to his chest. She smiles, inclining her head to him, and then she is gone.

Within the warmth of the gallery, Mydei leans over Phainon’s shoulder. “What is it? What’s wrong?”

Phainon turns back to him, to the portrait of Mydei he took so many months ago, to the people crowded around him. “Nothing, really,” he says, thinking of the woman in the window. He rubs his hand over his chest. “But my heart suddenly feels lighter.”



Chapter End Notes

special thanks to kimiko, who drew the gorgeous art for this chapter. please give them a follow over on bsky!

thank you all for giving this fic a chance, and for all your tears after last chapter. i hope this happy ending makes up for it <3

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

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